



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi cuts the fuel habit; bets big on Metro, EVs...



NATION: Pg 5

Suspense peaks in Kerala CM race



FILM: Pg 12

'Kartavya is one of the best roles that have come my way'

Import duty on gold, silver more than doubled to curb imports, support rupee

MPOST BUREAU



NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday sharply increased import duties on gold and silver to 15 per cent from 6 per cent, in a move aimed at curbing non-essential imports and protecting foreign exchange reserves under strain from rising oil and fertiliser costs linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

The decision came days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens to avoid discretionary spending such as buying gold and undertaking unnecessary foreign travel, while also calling for fuel conservation to support the domestic currency.

India, the world's second-largest consumer of precious metals after China, has witnessed a sustained rise in gold demand, partly driven by investment interest amid global uncertainty. Gold remains the country's second-largest import after crude oil, and increasing **Continued on P4**

PM Modi cuts down convoy size; BJP CMs, other leaders follow suit

NO AUSTERITY, ONLY EFFICIENCY, CENTRE CLARIFIES AFTER PM'S APPEAL

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has scaled down the size of his official convoy during recent domestic visits, days after urging citizens and government functionaries to adopt more efficient spending practices and reduce fuel consumption in view of global uncertainties.

Officials said the reduction was implemented in states such as Gujarat and Assam soon after the prime minister's address in Hyderabad, where he outlined measures to limit unnecessary imports and conserve foreign exchange. The revised convoy arrangements, they added, retain all essential security elements



in line with Special Protection Group protocols. According to government

sources, the initiative is part of a broader push to promote prudent use of resources

rather than a reduction in public spending. "This is not about cutting expenditure on

welfare, capital outlay or subsidies," an official said. **Continued on P4**

TAKEAWAYS

- » Convoy downsizing implemented in Gujarat and Assam
- » Security arrangements remain intact under SPG protocol
- » Government clarifies no cuts to welfare, subsidies or capital expenditure
- » Focus is on efficiency, not austerity, officials say
- » Cabinet ministers asked to limit resource use amid West Asia crisis

» MINISTERS URGED TO REDUCE CONVOY SIZES AND FOREIGN TRAVEL

NEET paper leak: CBI arrests 5, conducts multiple searches

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI/JAIPUR: The probe into the alleged leak of the NEET-UG 2026 question paper widened on Wednesday as the Central Bureau of Investigation arrested five individuals and carried out searches across multiple cities, even as protests intensified and political tensions escalated over the cancellation of one of India's largest entrance examinations.

The arrests came a day after the National Testing Agency scrapped the May 3 exam amid allegations that the paper had been compromised, leaving more than 22 lakh medical aspirants uncertain about their academic future. Demonstrations were reported in several states, with opposition parties demanding accountability and calling for the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.



One of the five persons, arrested in the NEET UG paper leak case, being produced before a judge PTI

CLOSER LOOK

- » Arrested include Mangilal, Vikas, Dinesh Biwal, Yash Yadav, Shubham Khairnar
- » Over 22 lakh medical aspirants affected nationwide
- » Protests intensified; opposition demanded resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan
- » Accused alleged "influential people protected, ordinary harassed" during custody transfer

According to officials, those arrested include Mangilal Biwal, **Continued on P4**

Trump lands in Beijing for high-stakes talks with Xi on trade, tech, Iran and Taiwan



President Donald Trump walks with China's Vice President Han Zheng during a welcome ceremony on Wednesday AP/PTI

BEIJING: US President Donald Trump arrived in Beijing on Wednesday for a two-day visit focused on trade, technology and geopolitical tensions, including Iran and Taiwan. He was received at the airport by Chinese Vice President Han Zheng, in a departure from standard protocol, alongside a guard of honour, brass band and 300 flag-waving students chanting a welcome.

Trump, last in China in 2017, is set to hold multiple

rounds of talks with Chinese President Xi Jinping. "My very first request" will be to ask China to "open up", Trump said, calling Xi a "leader of extraordinary distinction".

Top executives including Elon Musk, Tim Cook, and Nvidia's Jensen Huang joined the delegation, underlining the focus on semiconductors and trade. Discussions are also expected on rare earths, supply chains and the Iran conflict. **See P8**

Centre extends CBI chief's tenure by one more year

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has approved a one-year extension for Praveen Sood as director of the Central Bureau of Investigation, pushing his tenure beyond May 24, 2026. This marks his second extension since taking charge in May 2023.

Sood, a 1986-batch Indian Police Service officer of the Karnataka cadre, originally assumed office on May 25, 2023, for a two-year term. He was granted his first one-year extension in 2025. The latest decision was cleared by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet following a **Continued on P4**

TVK govt wins trust vote as AIADMK rebel group cross-votes in Tamil Nadu

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: The four-day-old TVK government in Tamil Nadu on Wednesday comfortably won the trust vote with the support of 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs amid DMK's walkout.

The Opposition made allegations of horse-trading that were rejected by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay.

In its confidence-boosting win, TVK romped home by a 144:22 margin, with all the 22 naysayers being the AIADMK MLAs owing allegiance to party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami. The 25 other party MLAs, from the C V Shanmugam-SP Velumani camp voted in favour of the government, as announced by them earlier.

Replying to discussions over the resolution moved by him seeking vote of confidence, Vijay said his government will always be secular and would continue



TVK MLAs show a thumbs-up sign after the floor test PTI

AIADMK chief Palaniswami removes 25 MLAs for backing CM Vijay in floor test

to implement the welfare schemes launched by previous regimes.

While the main opposition DMK, with 59 MLAs in the 234-member House staged a walkout slamming the government, PMK with 4 MLAs and the lone member of the BJP abstained.

Continued on P4

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav's younger brother Prateek Yadav dies of cardiac arrest at 38

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Prateek Yadav, younger brother of Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, died in Lucknow on Wednesday morning following a cardiac arrest. He was 38.

According to officials, Prateek was brought to the Civil Hospital in Lucknow

around 6 am by his brother-in-law Aman Singh Bisht, where doctors declared him dead on arrival.

Chief Medical Superintendent of Civil Hospital Dr D C Pandey said Prateek had no pulse when he was brought in and his heart had already stopped functioning. **Continued on P4**

Over 85% students clear CBSE Class 12 board exams; pass percentage dips

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) announced Class 12 examination results on Wednesday, with more than 85 per cent of candidates clearing the exams this year. The overall pass percentage, however, registered a decline of over three percentage points compared to last year.

Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj confirmed the figures, noting that while a large majority of students succeeded, performance trends showed a slight dip. High achievers continued to feature prominently, with 94,028 candidates, accounting for 5.32 per cent, securing 90 per cent and above. Among them, 17,113 students or 0.97 per cent scored 95 per cent or higher. **Continued on P4**

CBSE Class XII Results 2026

	Number of Schools	Number of Exam Centers
2025	19,299	7,330
2026	19,967	7,573

	Students Registered	Appeared	Passed
2025	17,04,367	16,92,794	14,96,307
2026	17,80,365	17,68,968	15,07,109

Pass Percentage				
	Overall	Girls	Boys	Third Gender
2025	88.39%	91.64%	85.70%	100%
2026	85.20%	88.86%	82.13%	100%

Region-wise Pass Percentage 2026: Top 5				
■ Trivandrum	■ Chennai	■ Bengaluru	■ Vijayawada	■ Delhi West
95.62%	93.84%	93.19%	92.77%	92.34%

Source: CBSE KBK InfoGraphics

Amul, Mother Dairy hike milk prices by Rs 2/litre

NEW DELHI: leading dairy sellers Amul and Mother Dairy have raised milk prices by Rs 2 per litre from May 14, citing rising input costs. The move, their second hike in 13 months, comes amid elevated food inflation, which crossed 4 per cent in April due to the West Asia conflict.

GCMF said the increase reflects higher spending on cattle feed, packaging and fuel, adding it equals "about 2.5-3.5 per cent per litre." It also raised farmers' procurement prices by Rs 30 per kg of fat.

Mother Dairy said costs paid to farmers rose about 6 per cent over the past year, calling the revision a "partial pass-through" to balance producer and consumer interests. **See P10**

विरासत से प्रगति तक हर कदम पर आपके साथ, हिन्दुस्तान जिंक

विश्व का सबसे बड़ा एकीकृत जिंक उत्पादक और शीर्ष दस चांदी उत्पादकों में से एक, भारत से जुड़ा हिन्दुस्तान जिंक जिम्मेदार, लो-कार्बन ग्रोथ को आगे बढ़ाते हुए माडर्न डेवलपमेंट के साथ अग्रणी है।

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ALIPUR AREA

Three killed, four injured after truck hits autorickshaw

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three people, including a minor girl, were killed while four others sustained injuries after an autorickshaw was hit by a truck from behind in Delhi's Alipur area on Wednesday, police said.

According to the police, information about the road accident was received at the Alipur police station, following which a team rushed to the spot near Shiv Mandir in the area. A total of seven people were travelling in the autorickshaw at the time of the accident.

On reaching the spot, police found a damaged autorickshaw and several injured passengers lying nearby. The injured were immediately rushed to nearby hospitals for treatment, a police officer said.

A Delhi Fire Services officer said two persons trapped inside the auto were rescued using emergency equipment. "Five other injured were already taken out by the public and a PCR staff before our arrival," he said. "All the injured were taken to Raja Harish Chandra Hospital in Narela, where three persons, including a child, were declared brought dead," the officer added. However, four of them have shifted to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Narayan Hospital due to the seriousness of their injuries, he said.

The victims were identified as Mukesh, his wife Pinki, their six-year-old son and their nine-year-old daughter, Chotu Pandit (28), a resident of Bihar's Champaran, autorickshaw driver Raju Sharma (52), a resi-

Noida Airport fares revised

OUR CORRESPONDENT

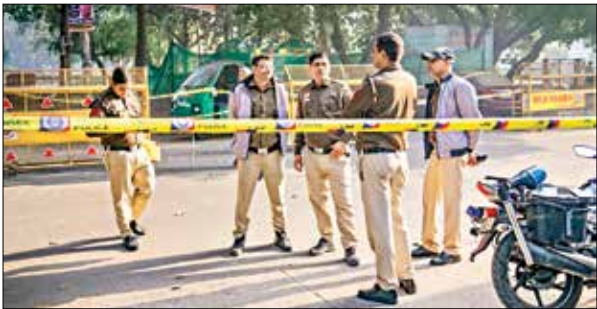
NOIDA: Noida International Airport passengers may finally get the low-cost air travel they were promised, with airlines sharply reducing fares on key domestic routes ahead of the airport's commercial launch.

After facing criticism over higher-than-expected ticket prices from Jewar airport compared to Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport, airlines including IndiGo and Akasa Air have revised fares downward for several sectors, making travel from Noida cheaper or at par with Delhi on some routes.

The fare revision comes as a major relief for passengers in Noida, Greater Noida and western Uttar Pradesh, who were expecting the upcoming airport to offer affordable and convenient connectivity. Earlier fare announcements had triggered disappointment among travellers and concern among local public representatives, as prices from Noida were significantly higher than Delhi despite the airport being projected as an alternative aviation hub.

Jewar MLA Dharendra Singh had written to both the Centre and the Uttar Pradesh government, urging intervention to ensure competitive pricing from the airport.

Akasa Air has announced the steepest fare cuts. For June 16 travel, the airline reduced the Noida-Bengaluru fare from Rs 8,532 to Rs 6,500. In comparison, Delhi-Bengaluru tickets are currently priced at Rs 6,998, making the Noida route cheaper. Similarly, fares for Navi Mumbai were slashed from Rs 6,505 to Rs 4,998, against Delhi's Rs 5,499. IndiGo has also revised fares on select sectors. The Noida-Lucknow ticket, which earlier cost Rs 4,981 for June 15 travel compared to Delhi's Rs 3,394, has now been reduced to Rs 3,394, matching Delhi rates. However, Noida-Bengaluru fares on IndiGo continue to remain slightly higher than Delhi.



Rapido driver & passenger killed after truck rams bike

GURUGRAM: A Rapido motorcycle driver and a passenger were killed after a speeding truck hit their vehicle in Gurugram's Sector 95, police said on Wednesday.

The police identified the deceased passenger as Rohit Kumar Gupta (29), a resident of Lucknow working with a private company in Delhi and the driver as Jaipal (24), a native of Auraiya in Uttar Pradesh. Gupta lived as a tenant in Shanti Vihar, Sector 95. Gupta had booked a

Rapido ride on Tuesday morning to commute to his office in Delhi. While the two were heading towards Delhi, a truck coming from behind allegedly hit the bike after it crossed Sati Chowk.

Both suffered serious injuries and were rushed to a private hospital in Sector 90 by passersby, the police said.

Police registered FIR against unidentified truck driver; CCTV footage is being scanned to identify the vehicle.

dent of Karawal Nagar, and one unidentified passenger.

Among them, Raju Sharma, the nine-year-old girl and the unidentified passenger died in the accident. Police said the condition of some of the injured persons is being closely monitored, and statements of the survivors will be recorded once they are declared fit by doctors. Investigators said they are examining all possi-

ble angles related to the accident, including whether the autorickshaw lost balance due to speeding, mechanical failure, poor road conditions or possible negligence. Police teams are also scanning CCTV cameras installed near the accident spot and adjoining roads.

The damaged autorickshaw has been taken into custody for mechanical inspection and forensic examination.

Mystery man posing as AC mechanic to rob residents apprehended in Capital; linked to viral armed attacks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 55-year-old man who allegedly posed as an AC and RO mechanic to rob residents in northwest Delhi's Keshav Puram and Pitampura areas has been arrested, police said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Ajay Bagga alias Vijay Bagga, was apprehended following an extensive manhunt involving CCTV analysis, technical surveillance and local enquiries,

'Once a resident opened the door, he would forcibly enter the house and launch an attack'

they said. According to police, Bagga used to roam through residential colonies posing as a mechanic and ring doorbells to identify potential targets.

"The moment a resident opened the door, he would forcibly enter the house, launch a sudden attack and rob the occupants," a police officer said. The accused had sent locals

into panic after CCTV footage of him roaming in residential areas holding a plastic blue bag and hiding a 'gandas' (machete) surfaced online, triggering a police hunt.

"A special team was formed to nab the accused after multiple incidents with a similar modus operandi were reported," Deputy Commis-

sioner of Police (Northwest) Akanksha Yadav said in a statement.

She further said that using technical surveillance, CCTV footage analysis and human intelligence inputs, police tracked down and arrested Bagga near Gurudwara Nanak Pyau in Model Town.

Police said Bagga has been linked to two separate FIRs registered at Maurya Enclave and Keshav Puram police stations. "In the first case, the com-

plainant Sahil Kukreja alleged that Bagga, who was known to him for the past eight to nine years, came to his residence in Pitampura on April 21 on the pretext of meeting his father," the officer said.

After allegedly robbing a man of Rs 4 lakh and jewellery at knife-point in one case and posing as an RO mechanic to target a woman in another, the accused was identified through CCTV footage and arrested after searches across 50 hotels.

Man accused of duping job seeker of ₹9.25 lakh nabbed

Accused lived in hotels under assumed name: Cops

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of the Delhi Police has arrested a man for allegedly running a visa and overseas job fraud racket and cheating a Delhi resident of Rs 9.25 lakh, officials said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Anup Dharmole (37), a resident of Jategaon village in Ahilya Nagar district of Maharashtra, was arrested from a hotel in Panvel following a multi-state investigation.

Police said the fraud came to light after a complaint was lodged at the Cyber Police Station in North-West Delhi by Vijay Narang, a resident of Shalimar Bagh.

According to investigators, Narang had applied for an overseas job through Naukri.com, following which he was contacted on WhatsApp by a person posing as a visa consultant. The accused allegedly extracted Rs 9.25 lakh from the complainant on the pretext of visa processing, clearances and overseas placement formalities. An e-FIR was registered on March 24 under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya



A team led by Inspector Dinesh Dahiya carried out technical surveillance, conducted multiple raids before arresting the accused

Sanhita. During the investigation, police traced suspicious financial transactions and call records to Mumbai. Officials found that the accused had allegedly been living in hotels under fake identities and operating the fraud network using pseudonyms to evade detection.

Police said Dharmole used

Fugitive in 358-kg heroin haul case brought back

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fugitive wanted in a major narcotics case was brought back from Azerbaijan by the Special Cell of Delhi Police, who secured his extradition in coordination with the CBI, officials said on Wednesday.

The accused, Prabhdeep Singh, was wanted in a 2021 case involving the recovery of 358 kilograms of heroin and had been absconding since 2023, they said.

A three-member Special Cell team travelled to Azerbaijan's capital Baku and brought Prabhdeep back to India after completing the extradition formalities, said an official statement.

According to police, Prabhdeep allegedly handled the India operations of an international drug syndicate run by his cousin Navpreet Singh alias



Nav, a foreign-based drug kingpin whose last known location was Turkey.

"Prabhdeep acted as a key conduit between Navpreet Singh and other members of the syndicate operating in India. He allegedly passed instructions from Navpreet to two arrested accused, Gurpreet Singh and Gurjot Singh, from whom 333 kilograms of heroin was recovered during an investigation," it read.

Police said Prabhdeep also monitored the movement of

Prabhdeep allegedly handled the India operations of an international drug syndicate run by his cousin Navpreet Singh alias Nav

narcotics consignments and remained in constant contact with other associates of the syndicate. He would be interrogated on the details of his role in the syndicate, and to gather more information regarding the international drug network, they said. According to police, the case dates back to July 2021. The Special Cell received information about Rizwan Ahmed alias Rizwan Kashmiri, who was allegedly involved in drug trafficking across Delhi and several states, including Pun-

jab, Haryana and Madhya Pradesh. "On July 5, 2021, acting on a tip-off, police intercepted Rizwan in the Ghitorni area of south Delhi when he was allegedly going to deliver a heroin consignment. One kilogram of heroin was recovered from his possession, following which he was arrested," read a police statement.

During interrogation, Rizwan allegedly disclosed that he worked under the directions of an Afghan national identified as Isha Khan. He also revealed his links with Punjab residents Gurpreet Singh and Gurjot Singh, who were allegedly operating a drug network from Faridabad in Haryana. Subsequently, police raided their hideouts in Faridabad and arrested both accused.

"On their instance, police recovered 166 kilograms of heroin from a car and another 115 kilograms from a second car.

Additionally, around 70 kilograms of heroin and psychotropic substances were recovered from their rented accommodation," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Praveen Kumar Tripathi said in the statement.

Further investigation led to the arrest of another Afghan national, Hazrat Ali, from Gurugram. Police recovered 2 kilograms of heroin and around 100 kilograms of chemicals allegedly used in the preparation of narcotic substances from his possession. Investigators later found that Gurpreet Singh had come in contact with Navpreet Singh while both were lodged in Kapurthala jail in Punjab in connection with separate narcotics cases.

So far, 11 accused, including one Afghan national, have been arrested in the case. The trial against 10 accused is currently underway, police said.

72-yr-old CA abducted after robbery at Sainik Farms home; 2 nabbed

NEW DELHI: A 72-year-old chartered accountant was robbed, assaulted, taped and kidnapped from his residence in south Delhi's Sainik Farms area by three men who barged into his house when he was alone, Delhi Police said on Wednesday.

The accused abandoned the victim and his car on the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway when they failed to extort an amount of Rs 50 lakh from him, they said. Two of the accused were arrested after a 36-hour chase, while efforts are underway to nab the remaining suspect, they added.

A senior police officer said that the incident took place around 7.45 pm on May 2.

"The elderly man was alone when three individuals forcibly broke into his residence. The accused overpowered him, assaulted him and restrained him using tape," the officer said.

The accused allegedly looted Rs 5 lakh kept in an almirah, Rs 8,000-10,000 from a drawer, a purse containing cash, three rings, and important documents, including the victim's Aadhaar card, driving licence, credit card and a mobile phone, he said.

The accused then forcibly took the victim in his own vehicle and drove towards Meerut. "During the journey, the kidnappers allegedly demanded an amount of Rs 50 lakh from the victim. They forced him to contact an acquaintance to arrange Rs 15 lakh on the pretext of an accident," the officer said.

When the victim failed to get the money, the accused abandoned him along with his



vehicle on the Delhi-Mumbai Highway at Firozpur Jhirka area in Haryana.

The victim later approached the police and underwent a medical examination. Doctors found simple blunt injuries on his body, the officer added.

"A PCR call regarding the incident was received at Neb Sarai police station on May 3, following which a case was registered under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sections that pertain to kidnapping, robbery, assault on his body, the officer added.

Considering the seriousness of the offence, he said, multiple police teams were formed to investigate the case and arrest the accused. The teams analysed CCTV footage, conducted local enquiries and used technical surveillance to identify the accused.

"After sustained efforts and a 36-hour chase, police apprehended two accused from Mathura in Uttar Pradesh. The arrested accused were identified as Surender, a resident of Fatehabad in Haryana (31), and a 40-year-old woman from Kalkaji in Delhi," said the police officer. Police have not disclosed the identity or other details of the victim.

ABVP workers protest outside NTA office

NEW DELHI: Members of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) on Wednesday staged a protest outside the National Testing Agency (NTA) office in Delhi over the cancellation of the NEET-UG 2026 examination following allegations of paper leak and irregularities.

Raising slogans against the NTA, the protestors demanded strict action against those responsible for the alleged irregularities and called for greater transparency in the conduct of competitive examinations.

During the protest, several ABVP members attempted to enter the NTA office premises and jump police barricades installed outside the building. However, they were stopped and pushed back by personnel of the Delhi Police and the Rapid Action Force (RAF) deployed at the spot.

Heavy security arrangements were put in place outside the NTA office to prevent any untoward incident.

"No one will be allowed to breach the law and order situation. Heavy security has been deployed outside the NTA office," a senior police officer said.

Delhi cuts the fuel habit; bets big on Metro, EVs...

PM MODI’S AUSTERITY PUSH: WALK-TO-WORK PUSH, CARPOOLING AND EV DRIVE GAIN MOMENTUM

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As Delhi pushes for a cleaner and less congested future, the Capital is witnessing a coordinated shift towards public transport, electric mobility and transit-linked urban planning. While Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday reviewed Delhi’s ambitious Transit Oriented Development (TOD) policy aimed at building “Walk-to-Work” communities, the Delhi government simultaneously rolled out a series of fuel-conservation and sustainability measures across departments following Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal to reduce petroleum consumption.

Chairing a meeting with Delhi Development Authority (DDA) officials, Sandhu stressed that promoting high-density and mixed-use development around Metro and Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS) stations would help create a “future-ready Delhi”. “Guided

by PM Narendra Modi’s vision for a Viksit Bharat, this transformative policy will redefine Delhi’s urban landscape and skyline,” he said.

The LG said the policy seeks to reduce congestion, improve mobility and expand access to affordable housing by creating integrated station hubs where citizens can “live, work and shop” without depending heavily on private vehicles. Under the TOD policy, planned high-density and mixed-use development will be encouraged within a 500-metre radius of Metro and RTS corridors, covering nearly 207 square kilometres across the city.

The policy builds upon the vision outlined in the Master Plan for Delhi 2021 and is expected to strengthen transit-linked urban growth while improving accessibility and housing availability along Metro corridors.

Echoing the broader push towards sustainable mobility, Delhi Chief Minister



Rekha Gupta announced that the Delhi Government has decided to limit the use of official vehicles in response to the Prime Minister’s appeal for fuel conservation.

“Prime Minister Narendra Modi has called upon citizens to conserve petrol and diesel and turn energy conservation into a mass movement in view of the current global situation,” Gupta said. She added that Cabinet



ministers, BJP MLAs, government departments and officials had begun minimising vehicle usage, while carpooling and public transport would now be prioritised.

The CM urged Delhi residents to use Metro and bus services for office commutes and daily travel, saying the city already has a strong transport network extending across NCR cities. She noted that Delhi Metro’s 416-kilometre network now operates over 4,500 trips daily through 343 trains and 303 stations, carrying more than 65 lakh passengers every day.

Gupta also highlighted the government’s push towards electric mobility, stating that DTC currently operates 6,300 buses, including 4,538 electric buses. The government aims to increase the electric bus fleet to 7,500 by the end of 2026 and

14,000 by 2028. In line with these efforts, the Public Works Department (PWD) issued a detailed set of directions for immediate implementation across all units. The department directed officials to minimise vehicle usage, promote public transport and electric vehicles, and adopt carpooling for inspections, field visits and office travel. Officers have also been instructed to travel together during inaugurations and official events wherever possible.

The department said virtual meetings would be encouraged to reduce avoidable travel, while one day every week would be observed as a “No Car Day”. All PWD offices have also been directed to install EV charging infrastructure. Additionally, PWD has been asked to maximise the use of electric pumps instead of diesel-operated pumps and ensure only organic manure is used in horticulture operations. The department will also expedite the establishment of green waste processing plants. Importantly, all foreign visits by officers, both official and personal, have been cancelled until further orders, and weekly compliance reports have been made mandatory. The government has also advised all PWD residential quarters to encourage the use of carpooling and public transport for commuting to offices.

PWD Minister Parvesh

Sahib Singh said, “Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s call is not just about reducing fuel consumption, it is about bringing discipline and responsibility into the system.” “In PWD, and equally across DJB and Irrigation & Flood Control, we are taking these directions in full spirit, not as a formality, but as a commitment,” he said.

“This is not about limiting work, it is about aligning our priorities with the needs of the country. When the government leads by example, change follows naturally. And that is exactly the direction we are moving in,” the minister added.

Meanwhile, other ministers also joined the fuel conservation campaign by using public transport on Wednesday. Minister Kapil Mishra travelled by Metro and urged citizens to adopt buses and Metro services, while Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh commuted by a DTC bus and interacted with passengers to assess commuter concerns.

MCD heatwave measures target workers, strays, and residents

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Amid the intensifying heatwave in the national capital, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi has launched several measures under its Heat Action Plan to protect sanitation workers, residents, and stray animals from extreme temperatures.

The civic body has arranged cold drinking water and ORS solutions at Sanitary Inspector offices and roll-call sites across Delhi to prevent dehydration among field staff. Caps have also been distributed to sanitation workers working under direct sunlight. Additionally, two vehicles equipped with water and ORS supplies have been deployed in each zone.

The MCD has also made arrangements for animals and birds by placing earthen water pots at dog-feeding points and inside public parks.

Officials said the initiative aims to safeguard frontline workers engaged in maintaining sanitation services during the severe summer conditions.



DDA boosts sports infra in South Delhi

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority is steadily transforming its sports infrastructure into accessible community spaces, with the DDA Squash and Badminton Stadium near Kamla Nehru College emerging as a major recreational and fitness hub in South Delhi.

Located in New Delhi’s Siri Fort sports complex area, the stadium offers a wide range of facilities catering to both professional athletes and fitness enthusiasts under its “Pay and Play” model. The complex houses 26 badminton courts, of which 18 are dedicated to public play while eight are reserved for coaching academies. The venue also features 11 squash courts, including an all-glass squash court for professional matches and practice sessions. Six courts are available

City nears rollout of logistics, warehousing policy

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced that the city is in the final stages of implementing a comprehensive Logistics and Warehousing Policy aimed at modernising freight movement, reducing congestion, and attracting investment. The policy focuses on developing logistics hubs on the outskirts, integrating green and digital systems, and simplifying procedures to position Delhi as an efficient and sustainable logistics hub.

The Chief Minister said the policy will make freight movement faster, more efficient, and cost-effective while improving ease of doing business. “The policy is designed to reduce congestion caused by goods transport, bring down pollution levels, and transform Delhi into a modern, efficient and environmentally sustainable logistics hub,” she said.

Under the plan, Urban Consolidation and Logistics Distribution Centres (UCLDCs) will be developed in peripheral areas to aggregate cargo and streamline deliveries. Localised storage hubs and micro-fulfilment centres will ensure faster last-mile delivery. “Localised storage hubs and micro-fulfilment centres will also be set up to ensure faster and more organised last-mile deliveries,” Gupta added.

The government will modernize Inland Container Depots (ICDs), develop dedicated logistics corridors, truck terminals,

and parking hubs, and create cold storage facilities near mandis to reduce traffic pressure within the city. “Cold storage facilities will be created near

mandis to strengthen storage and transportation systems and reduce traffic pressure within the city,” she said. Environmental sustainability is a key feature, with electric vehicles for last-mile delivery, solar-powered warehousing, and energy-efficient infrastructure. A digital platform, the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP), will enable real-time tracking and better management of goods. “The use of advanced technologies will make freight and delivery systems more transparent and efficient,” Gupta said.

The policy will benefit sectors including e-commerce, textiles, construction materials, fruits and vegetables, and electronics while creating jobs in warehousing, transport, logistics

Delhi L-G Sandhu directs DDA for drain desilting by June 15

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu on Wednesday directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to ensure desilting of all its drains ahead of the rainy season in the city. Sandhu reviewed the ‘Desilting Action Plan-2026’ of the DDA and warned that no laxity will be tolerated regarding quality of work and timeline for desilting of all drains by June 15, officials said.

The DDA officials informed the LG that a Central Flood Control Room is being set up

for effective monitoring and water-logging prone locations under authority’s jurisdiction during the rainy season. Eleven water-logging prone locations fall under the DDA jurisdiction, including maximum 10 in the South zone and one in the East zone. These locations include Okhla Underpass, Dwarka Flyover side Road (Maharaja Agrasen Hospital), Radha Swami T Point (Pochanpur to Janki Chowk via Jal Board Office, Sector-23, Dwarka), Sector-6/7 Crossing Dwarka. Other

water-logging prone locations under DDA jurisdiction are: Jal Board T Point Janki Chowk (Sector-22, Dwarka), Sarita Vihar Okhla Underpass, Okhla Underpass (Harkesh Nagar), Dwarka Court, Pathar Market Sector-20 Dwarka, Sector 22 & Sector 23 Dwarka and Utsav Park Patparganj.

Sandhu emphasised that the DDA should act as a role model for other agencies and ensure that its works are befitting the stature of Delhi as a global Capital.

MPOST

RWAs, NGOs get Rs 13.36 cr for parks

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government released over Rs 13 crore in 2025-26 for maintenance of 1,643 parks through RWAs and NGOs, marking the highest financial assistance since 2008-09, according to official data. Data by the Delhi Parks and Gardens Society showed that Rs 13.36 crore was released in the year for maintenance of parks spread across 484.37 acres through 364 resident welfare associations (RWAs) and non-government organisations. In comparison, Rs 7.05 crore was released in 2024-25 for maintenance of 1,483 parks covering 435.57 acres through 329 RWAs and NGOs under the ‘Delhi Parks and Garden Society’ scheme. The data showed that in 2025-26, the number of associations and organisations covered under the scheme increased by 35, while 160 more parks and an additional 48.80 acres were brought under maintenance support compared to the previous financial year. The financial assistance released also rose by Rs 6.31 crore, an increase of nearly 89.6 per cent over 2024-25. According to the data, Rs 13.36 crore released in 2025-26 is the highest financial assistance recorded under the scheme since 2008-09. MPOST

CBSE CLASS 12 RESULTS Delhi govt schools, girls excel

NEW DELHI: Government schools in the national capital recorded an overall pass percentage of 94.44 per cent in the CBSE Class 12 examinations this year, outperforming private schools, which registered a pass percentage of 88.77 per cent, the Board’s data released on Wednesday showed.

Among government schools, girls recorded a pass percentage of 96.10 per cent, while boys stood at 92.49 per cent. In private schools, the pass percentage was 91.43 per cent for girls and 86.79 per cent for boys, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) result data showed.

Overall, Delhi recorded a pass percentage of 92.10 per cent. Girls outperformed boys by 6.73 percentage points, with girls registering a pass percentage of 88.86 per cent against 82.13 per cent for boys.

According to the data, a total of 3,01,977 students had registered for the examination in the overall Delhi region, of whom 3,00,732 appeared and 2,76,583 passed. The Delhi-East region recorded an overall pass percentage of 91.73 per cent, while the Delhi-West region recorded a slightly higher pass percentage of 92.34 per cent.

Since 2020, CBSE has not

published any official list of toppers to reduce unhealthy competition among students. However, several schools in the national capital also announced their stream-wise toppers.

Among them, DPS Dwarka recorded the highest individual score, with Teghnor Singh securing 99.4 per cent in the Commerce stream. Upraj Bedi scored 97.8 per cent in Science, while Samajya Singh and Aarna Arora secured 97 per cent each in Humanities.

At DPS Vasant Kunj, Vivaan Sharma scored 98.6 per cent in Science, Devina Gahlot secured 98 per cent in Humanities, and

Anushri Tewari achieved 96.4 per cent in Commerce.

ITL International School, Dwarka, reported strong performances across streams, with Priyansh Mehra securing 98.25 per cent in Science. Viraj Kathuria and Akshat Shah scored 98.25 per cent each in Commerce, while Venus Sharma topped Humanities with 97.5 per cent.

At Tagore International School, East of Kailash, Zaina topped the Science stream with 97.25 per cent, Unnati Golani scored 96.75 per cent in Humanities, and Ayush Khanna secured 96.5 per cent in Commerce.

PTI



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PM MODI'S FIVE-NATION VISIT

UAE to Europe: India eyes stronger strategic and economic partnerships

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday, informed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's impending visit to five nations would focus on "trade, investment, technology, particularly green technology, innovation, start-ups, and of course, people-to-people connect," while also reinforcing India's long-term strategic partnerships across the Gulf and Europe.

Talking about the agenda, Sibi George, Secretary (West), added, "...discussions will be held on strengthening our bilateral cooperation. Discussions will also focus on strengthening our energy security. I repeat, energy security, which is an important aspect of our relationship."

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to undertake an important five-country visit from May 15 to May 20, which includes visits to the UAE and four other European nations — The Netherlands, Sweden, Norway, and Italy. The upcoming

Highlights

» Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to undertake an important five-country visit from May 15 to May 20

» The upcoming diplomatic visit holds much significance in light of India's rising need to ensure energy security and diversify its economic engagements

ing diplomatic visit holds much significance in light of India's rising need to ensure energy security and diversify its economic engagements amidst increasing global uncertainties.

To begin the tour with the UAE, on May 15, is taking place during a period of increasing tension in West Asia and apprehensions about the disruption of maritime security and energy flow channels.

According to George, the cooperation of energy would stay an important factor for

the discussion that Modi will be holding with UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

George emphasised that the consistent high-level political engagements still exist between India and the UAE through their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. While talking about the Indian diaspora residing in the Gulf country, he said, "We have 4.5 million Indians in the UAE and this is the living link of our partnership."

As for the European leg of the trip, its importance lies against the backdrop of the increasing cooperation between India and Europe through economic initiatives such as the India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement.

According to George, this engagement is part of India's overall vision in terms of economy and geopolitics in its 'Amrit Kaal' era when it hopes to develop and become a developed country by 2047. "India sees these countries as our partners in our 'Make in India'

initiative to make India a manufacturing hub," George stated.

Modi's visit to the Netherlands will be marked by meetings with the Dutch authorities and interactions with the business community and the Indian community.

According to George, "cooperation between India and the Netherlands is not limited to traditional areas like water, agriculture, and healthcare. It extends to technology, innovation, defence, security, semiconductors, renewable energy, education, and the maritime sector." George, further, pointed out that there was also a considerable Indian diaspora in the Netherlands, which has more than 90,000 Indians and people of Indian origin, and a substantial Surinamese-Hindustani population.

In Sweden, George described the relationship as increasingly innovation-driven, anchored in the India-Sweden Innovation Partnership launched in 2018. The senior official said Modi's visit to Gothenburg, on May 17,

would focus on areas such as artificial intelligence, resilient supply chains, green transition and defence cooperation. "Sweden, today, is one of the world's most innovative economies, and India and Sweden increasingly view each other as complementary innovation and technology partners," he added.

George also mentioned the expanding defence collaboration between the two nations, particularly the presence of the Carl-Gustaf manufacturing unit of Sweden-based defence firm Saab in the city of Hyderabad through the 100 per cent foreign direct investment route. Other areas of cooperation that he referred to include climate change and industrial transitions, such as the formation of the Leadership Group for Industry Transition. The upcoming visit of India's Prime Minister to Norway on May 18 is predicted to inaugurate a new era in the bilateral relationship. This will be the first time in four decades that an Indian Prime Minister visits the Nordic nation.

Jaishankar holds talks with Russia's Lavrov; trade, geopolitics top agenda

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: External Affairs minister S Jaishankar and Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov held "productive" talks on Wednesday to advance bilateral cooperation in energy and trade amid shifting geopolitical tensions.

Jaishankar met Lavrov, shortly after the Russian foreign minister landed in New Delhi to attend a two-day conclave of the BRICS member states beginning Thursday.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, Brazil's Foreign Minister Mauro Vieira and South Africa's Minister for International Relations Ozzy Lamola are among those who already arrived in the national capital for the BRICS foreign ministerial meeting.

Jaishankar and Lavrov are learnt to have deliberated on the West Asia crisis as well as the Ukraine conflict.

In a social media post, the external affairs minister described his talks with his Russian counterpart as "productive exchange of views".

"Our conversation touched upon several aspects of the India-Russia Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership,



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar with his Russian counterpart Sergey Lavrov, on the sidelines of the BRICS Foreign Ministers' meeting, in New Delhi PTI

including trade and investment, energy and connectivity, science and technology, as well as facilitating mobility of skills and talent," he said.

"Other global and multilateral issues of mutual interest were also discussed," he said.

It is not immediately known if India's procurement of Russian crude oil figured in the talks.

In his televised opening remarks at the meeting, Jaishankar said India and Russia have a shared interest in strengthening multipolarity and could benefit through greater "de-risking".

"The last few years have seen a steady and sustained growth in our bilateral partnership. Its economic and energy dimensions have become pronounced. Our political cooperation is even more valuable in an uncertain and volatile global environment," Jaishankar said.

"We have expanded our collaboration in science and technology. The mobility of talents and skills has acquired greater salience and our interest in ensuring better connectivity is deeper," he said.

"The complicated international situation also merits an open exchange of views, especially between two trusted partners," he said.

The external affairs minister said India and Russia have a shared interest in strengthening multipolarity.

Jaishankar also held separate bilateral talks with Brazilian Foreign Minister Vieira South Africa's Ozzy Lamola.

The external affairs minister also met Maldivian Foreign Minister Iruthisham Adam.

"Underlined our Neighbourhood First policy and reviewed our bilateral cooperation. Reiterated India's commitment to Maldives' progress and development," he said on X.

From Page 1 Import duty

purchases have contributed to pressure on the rupee, which hit a record closing low of 95.71 against the US dollar on Wednesday after touching 95.75 a day earlier.

Under the revised structure effective May 13, the import duty on gold and silver has been raised to 15 per cent from 6 per cent, while platinum now attracts a duty of 15.4 per cent compared to 6.4 per cent earlier. The changes extend to related items such as dore, coins and findings. The basic customs duty on gold has been doubled to 10 per cent and the agriculture infrastructure and development cess has been increased from 1 per cent to 5 per cent. Including a 3 per cent Integrated GST, the total tax incidence now stands at 18.45 per cent, up from 9.18 per cent.

Government officials described the move as a preventive step taken under "extraordinary external conditions". "During periods of external stress, measured moderation of discretionary imports may contribute significantly to overall macro-economic stability and prudent external-sector management," a source said.

Another official noted that the approach avoids harsher restrictions. "Rather than resorting to quantitative curbs, the policy uses price-based disincentives that preserve market flexibility and consumer choice," the source said, adding that the measure is neither prohibitory nor anti-consumer.

The backdrop to the decision is a surge in precious metals imports, which rose 26.7 per cent year-on-year to USD 102.5 billion in FY2025-26, accounting for 14 per cent of total imports compared with 11.8 per cent the previous year. Gold imports alone climbed more than 24 per cent to a record USD 71.98 billion, even as volumes declined 4.76 per cent to 721.03 tonnes, reflecting a sharp increase in prices.

Global and domestic gold prices have risen significantly. The average price increased from USD 76,617.48 per kg in FY25 to USD 99,825.38 per kg in FY26. In Delhi, gold prices rose by Rs 1,500 to Rs 1,56,800 per 10 grams on Tuesday, while silver surged by Rs 12,000 to Rs 2,77,000 per kg.

The broader economic context includes rising energy costs triggered by tensions in West Asia and disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz. Brent crude prices have climbed from about USD 73 per barrel before the conflict began on February 28 to around USD 107, after touching a four-year high of USD 126 on April 30.

India imports 87 per cent of its crude oil, with 46 per cent passing through or near the Strait of Hormuz. Additionally, 60 per cent of liquefied petroleum gas imports and more than 90 per cent of fertiliser shipments originate from the Gulf region. Officials said prioritising foreign exchange for essential imports such as energy, fertilisers and industrial inputs has become critical amid these conditions.

The duty hike is expected to increase domestic prices of gold and silver, potentially moderating

demand while easing pressure on the external account.

PM Modi cuts

"It is about using resources more efficiently by lowering fuel consumption and avoiding dependence on imported goods and services that require foreign exchange."

During a recent Union Cabinet meeting chaired by Modi, ministers were asked to consciously limit resource use and avoid avoidable expenditure, particularly in the context of the ongoing crisis in West Asia. The prime minister is also learnt to have advised ministers to reduce the size of their convoys and limit foreign travel.

Several states have since announced measures along similar lines. In Uttar Pradesh, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath ordered a 50 per cent reduction in the number of vehicles accompanying him and his ministers. He also called on citizens to adopt the prime minister's approach to mindful spending.

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said his convoy would operate with the minimum number of vehicles required for security. "There will be no vehicle rallies, and ministers will also limit the number of vehicles used," he stated, while encouraging greater use of public transport.

In Delhi, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced caps on official vehicle usage by ministers and legislators and urged residents to opt for carpooling and public transport. Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma issued similar directions, asking officials to reduce convoy sizes.

The Maharashtra government, led by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, has mandated prior approval for ministers seeking to use aircraft for official travel. Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde has switched to an electric vehicle, with ministers advised to limit non-essential travel.

Other leaders have also responded. Gujarat Governor Acharya Devvrat said he would rely on trains and public transport within the state, while Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Kumar Chaudhary halved his official vehicle usage. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu indicated that his government would soon announce steps to manage the impact of the West Asia situation.

Officials maintained that the measures should not be viewed as austerity, a term often linked to cuts in government spending and subsidies. Instead, they described the approach as a shift towards efficiency and conservation.

On Sunday, Modi had called for reduced petrol and diesel consumption, increased use of metro services, carpooling, electric mobility, rail transport for goods movement and work-from-home practices where feasible, as part of a broader effort to conserve energy and foreign exchange.

NEET paper leak

Vikas Biwal and Dinesh Biwal from Jaipur, Yash Yadav from Gurugram, and Shubham Khairnar from Nashik. Investigators said more suspects are being questioned and

further arrests are likely as the case develops.

One of the accused, speaking while being transported to Delhi, alleged selective targeting in the investigation. "Bade logon ko bachaya jata aur aam aadmi ko pareshan kiya jata hai," he said, claiming that influential figures were being shielded while ordinary individuals were being harassed.

The case, initially probed by Rajasthan Police's Special Operations Group, was handed over to the CBI. The agency has since seized several electronic devices, including mobile phones and laptops, which will undergo forensic examination to trace how the question paper or related material circulated prior to the test.

Investigators have outlined a complex chain through which the alleged leak spread. Officials said a "guess paper" containing questions similar to those asked in the exam was first traced to a medical student from Sikar district studying in Kerala. The material was reportedly shared among friends and a hostel owner, who then distributed it to students, suggesting it could be useful for preparation.

The hostel owner later alerted authorities, stating that the question bank had reached a large number of candidates. From Sikar, the material is believed to have been routed through contacts in Gurugram before reaching aspirants in Jaipur and nearby areas ahead of the exam.

Further leads point to Nashik as a possible origin point of the leak. One of the arrested, Shubham Khairnar, was taken into custody there and is being brought to Delhi on transit remand for further questioning.

Parallel investigations in Maharashtra's Latur, a well-known coaching hub, revealed that at least 42 questions in a mock test conducted by a private institute matched those in the NEET exam. Police questioned six individuals, including coaching staff, after a complaint from a parent triggered the inquiry.

Authorities said that in Rajasthan alone, more than 150 candidates, along with their friends and family members, have been questioned by joint teams from multiple districts as investigators attempt to map the full extent of the network.

The role of the Biwal brothers has drawn particular attention. Officials allege that one of them paid around Rs 30 lakh to obtain the exam paper through a consultant identified as Rakesh Mandawaria, linked to Sikar. Investigators suspect that the document was first accessed through a member of the family before being shared with others willing to pay for it.

The case has also taken on a political dimension. Opposition parties, including the Congress and the Trinamool Congress, have claimed that some of the accused have links to the Bharatiya Janata Party. Social media posts circulating photographs of Dinesh Biwal with senior BJP leaders, including Rajasthan minister Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore, have intensified the debate.

Family members of the accused have denied any wrongdoing. Dinesh Biwal's mother said her sons were being falsely implicated, while his wife insisted he could not be involved in such activities, noting that she had been in Sikar with their child for exam preparations.

Amid the growing controversy, the Federation of All India Medi-

cal Association approached the Supreme Court seeking a complete restructuring of the examination system. The plea calls for replacing the National Testing Agency with a technologically advanced and autonomous body to restore credibility to medical entrance tests.

Earlier, CBI officials visited the NTA headquarters in Delhi to collect documents related to the conduct of the exam as part of their investigation.

With the probe now spanning multiple states and involving digital evidence, financial transactions and institutional processes, authorities say the inquiry remains ongoing and could uncover a broader network behind the alleged leak. Meanwhile, uncertainty continues for millions of students awaiting clarity on when and how the crucial entrance test will be conducted again.

At least 31 killed

"Mobile networks were disrupted, which affected restoration and rescue operations," he said, adding that officials and police teams were deployed across all three tehsils to carry out relief work. Police said 16 people died in separate incidents in the district, while six others were injured, including two in serious condition.

Fatehpur reported nine deaths and 16 injuries. Additional District Magistrate Avinash Tripathi said eight of the victims, including five women, died in Khaga tehsil. "In Sadar tehsil, one woman died after a house wall collapsed," he said.

In Budaun, five people, including two minor girls aged 10 and 9, were killed in multiple incidents linked to strong winds and rain. The girls died after a mud wall collapsed in Siddhpur Kaitholi village, trapping them under debris along with two women who were seriously injured. In another case, a woman died when a tree fell on a tubewell structure, while three others were injured. Separate incidents involving falling trees also claimed two more lives, including a truck driver. Police said around five others were injured in the district.

In Sonbhadra, a 38-year-old man died after a tree fell on him while he had taken shelter during the storm.

Centre extends

recommendation from a high-level selection panel.

The committee, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, included Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi. According to officials, the panel met on Tuesday to finalise the extension.

Gandhi, however, recorded a dissent note, objecting to the process and stating he did not wish to be part of what he described as a "biased exercise".

Officials said the extension was granted to maintain continuity at the helm of the agency, which is currently handling several high-profile and politically sensitive investigations, including the NEET UG paper leak case. Sood is known for closely overseeing major probes and maintaining a hands-on approach in key cases.

Born in Kangra, Himachal Pradesh, in 1964, Sood joined the IPS at the age of 22 after graduating in civil engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi.

The extension has been granted under provisions introduced through amendments to the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946. The revised law, passed by Parliament in December 2021, allows the director's tenure to be extended annually in public interest, for up to five years in total.

The Supreme Court's 1997 ruling in the Vineet Narain case had earlier mandated a minimum tenure of two years for the CBI director to ensure functional stability.

TVK govt wins

The Vijay-led TVK government won the trust vote also due to the support from the Congress, VCK, Left, IUML and MLA S Kamaraj, who was expelled from AMMK for supporting TVK.

In an embarrassment, the split in the AIADMK came into the open during the trust vote proceedings as the faction led by party leaders Velumani-Shanmugam voted in favour of the government. AIADMK chief Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS) removed 25 leaders from their posts within the party. Among those removed were AIADMK leaders SP Velumani and C V Shanmugam.

Though minutes before Velumani announced support Palaniswami had declared in the House that his party MLAs must vote against the government. The Velumani-Shanmugam led group defied the diktat and sided with the TVK regime. Noisy scenes were witnessed as Palaniswami's faction opposed Velumani-Shanmugam group's announcement of support to the government.

In the 234-member House, 118 is the simple majority mark and at the time of voting TVK — which won 108 seats — had a strength of 105 as one party MLA was barred from voting by court; Vijay resigned from Tiruchi-East and Speaker JCD Prabhabhar cannot vote in the absence of a "tie" situation. Speaking on the trust vote, Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin said, "A majority of people did not vote for TVK." Only 1.72 crore people voted for the Vijay-led party and the remaining 3.21 crore people "voted against your party." Approximately 4.93 crore is the total number of people who voted in the April 23 polls.

Congress, IUML and VCK members were among those who spoke on the resolution supporting the government.

Vijay asserted that while the government functioned with "horse-speed", it does not engage in horse-trading.

The CM also alleged that DMK was rejected by the people and hence it may wish to insult TVK. On Udhayanidhi's jibe that a majority of people rejected TVK, Vijay sarcastically asked if DMK won 234 seats and secured 100 per cent votes when it formed the government in 2006. The DMK formed the government at that time with Congress party's support.

Defending their move to support Vijay, Shanmugam said TVK and AIADMK have similar ideological agenda where they see the

DMK as an "evil force," and this reason prompted a section of the AIADMK MLAs to support the government in the floor test, Shanmugam claimed.

Speaking to reporters after the floor test in Tamil Nadu Assembly, Shanmugam rejected Palaniswami's claim that they will get "ministerial berths" for supporting the Joseph Vijay-led TVK government.

AIADMK said that they have applied for the disqualification of 24 MLAs — who voted in favour of Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Vijay — under the anti-defection law.

"Since around 25 members acted against the whip, they are liable for losing their posts under the anti-defection law... We have submitted a petition today seeking their disqualification. If they (the rebels) vote against the whip issued by the party, the anti-defection law will apply to them," said the AIADMK, whose senior leaders held a press conference.

Prateek Yadav

A postmortem examination conducted at King George's Medical University stated that the immediate cause of death was cardiac arrest linked to pulmonary thromboembolism, a serious medical condition caused by blood clots blocking arteries in the lungs. Doctors said large blood clots were found in the lungs, leading to failure of both the heart and lungs.

The autopsy report mentioned injuries to his chest, under his right arm, right forearm, right elbow joint, over the elbow and left wrist.

"Injuries 1, 2, and 3 are about 5-7 days old. Injuries 4,5,6 are about one day old," the report added.

Medical officials said samples of the clots recovered from the heart and lungs have been preserved for further investigation, while internal organs have also been sent for chemical examination. Doctors added that all injury marks found on the body were ante-mortem in nature.

According to medical experts, pulmonary thromboembolism disrupts blood circulation and severely affects breathing by blocking pulmonary arteries with clotted blood.

Sources said Prateek had earlier been admitted to a private hospital in Lucknow on April 30 in critical condition. Though his health reportedly improved after three days, he later returned home without formal discharge. Doctors said he had been undergoing treatment for pulmonary embolism.

Following the postmortem, Prateek's body was brought to his residence. His last rites will be performed at Pipraghat crematorium in Lucknow on Thursday afternoon.

His wife, BJP leader Aparna Yadav, returned to Lucknow from Assam after receiving the news. She had travelled there to attend the swearing-in ceremony of Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. She went directly from the airport to the family residence.

Several political leaders, including Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Finance Minister Suresh Khanna, SP MP Dimple Yadav and senior SP leader

Shivpal Singh Yadav, visited the residence to pay their respects.

Earlier in the day, Akhilesh Yadav also reached the postmortem house and met family members and officials. Briefly speaking to reporters, he said, "It is painful that he is no longer among us. The family will decide the further course."

Congress state president Ajai Rai described the death as deeply unfortunate and expressed condolences to the family. He said Prateek was involved in social work and had been following the path shown by late SP patriarch Mulayam Singh Yadav.

Prateek was the son of Mulayam Singh Yadav's second wife, Sadhana Gupta. Born in 1988, he was publicly acknowledged by Mulayam Singh after his marriage to Sadhana Gupta in 2003.

In January this year, Prateek had publicly announced his decision to separate from Aparna Yadav, alleging differences in their relationship. However, the couple reconciled days later. In a social media post after the reconciliation, Prateek had shared a photograph with Aparna and written, "All is good." Prateek Yadav was associated with the real estate business and had been involved in several companies linked to his family members. Last year, he had filed an FIR at Gautampalli police station against a real estate businessman, accusing him of demanding Rs 5 crore in extortion.

CBSE board

The number of students placed in the compartment category rose notably. In 2026, 1,63,800 students, or 9.26 per cent of examinees, fell into this group, compared to 1,29,095 students or 7.63 per cent in 2025. These students have cleared most subjects but will need to reappear in one or two papers.

Girls once again recorded stronger results than boys, achieving a pass percentage of 88.86, while boys stood at 82.13 per cent. Transgender candidates achieved a complete pass rate.

Regional performance varied across the 22 CBSE zones. Trivandrum emerged at the top with a pass percentage of 95.62, followed by Chennai at 93.84 and Bengaluru at 93.19. At the lower end, Prayagraj recorded 72.43 per cent, while Patna stood at 74.45 per cent.

Among school categories, Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan led with a 98.55 per cent pass rate, followed closely by Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya at 98.47 per cent. Government schools reported 89.55 per cent, while independent schools recorded 84.22 per cent.

The examinations were conducted across 19,967 schools and 7,573 centres, with more than 5.06 lakh invigilators deployed. In a first, CBSE implemented full-scale digital evaluation through On Screen Marking, under which 98,66,22 answer books were assessed by around 70,000 evaluators.

Students placed in the compartment category or seeking improvement can appear for supplementary exams scheduled on July 15. The List of Candidates submission window will open on June 2. Results are available on the official CBSE website and DigiLocker.

RAHUL MEETS KHARGE TO DECIDE FINAL PICK

Suspense peaks in Kerala CM race as supporters gather at leaders’ homes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM/KOCHI: In Kerala, the homes of Congress Chief Minister hopefuls Ramesh Chennithala and V D Sathes-
aan remained crowded on Wednesday with anxious supporters through the day as suspense over the party’s leadership choice continued.

The wait finally eased late in the evening when AICC general secretary Jairam Ramesh, speaking in New Delhi, said the Congress high command would announce its decision on Thursday.

AICC general secretary for organisation, K C Venugopal, Leader of Opposition in the outgoing Kerala assembly, Sathes-
aan, and senior party leader Chennithala are among those in the race for the top post after the Congress-led UDF swept the April 9 elections.

As word spread that the



A man rides past posters supporting KC Venugopal and VD Sathes-
aan near the Congress headquarters, in Thiruvananthapuram PTI

Congress high command would take a final call after Rahul Gandhi met party president Mallikarjun Kharge in New Delhi on Wednesday evening, the homes of CM hopefuls Chennithala in Vazhuthacaud, Thiruvananthapuram, and Sathes-
aan in Aluva near Kochi became centres of tense anticipation.

Party workers from across

Kerala gathered outside both residences through the day, waiting for word from Delhi.

Supporters arriving from Haripad, Chennithala’s home constituency, as well as districts including Wayanad and Alappuzha, waited in clusters on the premises and nearby roadside, constantly tracking television channels and scrolling through mobile phones for

Highlights

» The wait finally eased late in the evening when AICC general secretary Jairam Ramesh, speaking in New Delhi, said the Congress high command would announce its decision on Thursday

» Party workers from across Kerala gathered outside both residences through the day, waiting for word from Delhi

updates emerging from the national capital.

Every passing phone call or television flash triggered fresh speculation among the workers, many of whom expressed confidence that the senior Congress leader would finally get the nod from the party high command.

“Everyone here has strong hope and excitement. We

believe Chennithala ji is the natural choice considering his long political and organisational experience,” said a woman party worker waiting outside the residence.

Another supporter who travelled from Haripad described him as “a leader who lives in the hearts of Kerala people” and said party workers across the state were eagerly awaiting a favourable announcement.

The atmosphere outside the residence remained charged with expectation as supporters continued to gather while the Congress central leadership held crucial discussions in Delhi over the leadership issue.

Meanwhile, a few Congress MLAs, including Mohammed Shiyas, visited Sathes-
aan’s home in the morning. As the day progressed, a large crowd of his supporters gathered outside his residence, hoping for his selection as chief minister.

CHENNAI: Veteran politician and founder of the All India N.R. Congress, N. Rangasamy, was sworn in as the Chief Minister of Puducherry for the fifth time on Wednesday, marking another significant chapter in the Union Territory’s political history.

The swearing-in ceremony was held in the presence of senior leaders of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), party workers, and supporters who gathered in large numbers to witness the event. K. Kailashnathan, the Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry, administered the oath of office and secrecy to Rangasamy and his Cabinet colleagues. The veteran leader took the oath in the name of God.

Along with Rangasamy, two ministers were also inducted into the new Cabinet. Malladi Krishna Rao of the AINRC and A. Namassivayam of the Bharatiya Janata Party



BJP’s Nitin Nabin poses with N Rangasamy

PTI

took oath as ministers in the AINRC-led NDA government. Krishna Rao, who represents Yanam — the Telugu-speaking enclave of Puducherry located in Andhra Pradesh — took oath in Telugu, reflecting the region’s cultural identity and linguistic diversity.

Several senior BJP leaders attended the ceremony, including BJP national president Nitin Nabin and senior party strategist B. L. Santhosh. Their presence highlighted the importance of the alliance between the BJP and AINRC in the Union Territory’s political

landscape.

The NDA alliance had secured victory in the April 9 Assembly elections, enabling the coalition to retain power in Puducherry. Following the election results, Droupadi Murmu officially appointed Rangasamy as the Chief Minister. Known for his simple lifestyle and grassroots connect, Rangasamy remains one of the most popular political figures in Puducherry. His return to office for a fifth term is being viewed as a strong endorsement of his leadership and governance style.

PM hails Cabinet’s decisions, sees relief for farmers, better connectivity

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday hailed the Union Cabinet’s approval to hike the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for 14 Kharif crops, a scheme to promote surface coal gasification projects and other rail and aviation projects, saying these will help farmers, strengthen connectivity, boost commerce and create new opportunities for growth.

In a series of posts on X, Modi said to safeguard the interests of the farmer brothers and sisters across the country and increase their income, the NDA government is continuously taking important decisions. “In this direction, our government has approved

an increase in the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for kharif crops for the marketing season 2026-27. This decision will ensure that crores of food providers in the country receive fair and profitable prices for their produce, while bringing greater prosperity to their lives,” he said.

On the Cabinet’s approval to upgrade the Nagpur International Airport through a public-private partnership, Modi said it is a major boost to the city’s infrastructure.

“The Cabinet decision relating to Nagpur Airport will accelerate its emergence as a key aviation and cargo hub. This will strengthen connectivity, boost commerce and create

new opportunities for growth,” he said. Commenting on the approval of the construction of a 134-km semi-high-speed double rail line between Ahmedabad and Dholera in Gujarat, the prime minister said it will strengthen Dholera’s rise as a major centre of opportunity, enterprise and future-ready infrastructure.

“Today’s Cabinet decision on the Ahmedabad (Sarkhej)-Dholera Semi High-Speed Double Line project is a landmark in India’s rail modernisation journey. Built with indigenously developed technology, this first-of-its-kind project will boost connectivity, reduce travel time and support growth in Gujarat.” AGENCIES

NEET row: Congress seeks Pradhan’s exit, JPC probe

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Wednesday demanded Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation over the cancellation of the NEET-UG exam and called for a probe by a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) into the “paper leak scandal”.

Congress’ youth wing chief Uday Bhanu Chib and president of its student’s wing NSUI Vinod Jakhar also demanded that the government provide appropriate compensation to the students affected by the cancellation of the examination.

“The NEET paper leak is a major issue. Over the last 10 years, 89 papers have been leaked, and re-examinations have been conducted 48 times. This implies that the government has completely abdicated its accountability towards the



Indian Youth Congress activists raise slogans during a protest in New Delhi PTI

students,” Chib said.

“If we were to put ourselves in the shoes of these students, perhaps we would be able to truly feel their pain. Students prepare diligently and sit for these exams, but when a paper gets leaked, they lose their faith in the system,” he said.

The Youth Congress president alleged that the BJP gov-

ernment is responsible for this failure. “The BJP claims that Prime Minister Narendra Modi can halt a war between two nations; yet, the reality is that he is not even able to prevent paper leaks,” Chib said.

He further raised questions regarding who conducts the audits for the NTA (National Testing Agency) and on what

Cong slams BJP over ‘political spectacle’, says poor and elderly are being ignored

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Wednesday attacked Prime Minister Narendra Modi for preaching austerity to citizens despite spending huge amounts on self-promotion and said the government has not bothered to increase old age pensions for the last 12 years.

In a post on X, Kharge accused the government of snatching the dignity of India’s elderly, widows and people with disabilities by not raising their paltry pensions.

“Narendra Modi ji, you lecture the country on austerity and sacrifice while snatching dignity from India’s elderly, widows, and persons with disabilities. Why? For 12 years,

Kharge accused the government of snatching the dignity of India’s elderly

the BJP has refused to increase old age pensions, even by a SINGLE PAISA, as Price Rise crushes our poor,” he said in his post.

“After a 45 per cent erosion in purchasing power, the Rs 200 pension is effectively worth about Rs 110 in today’s terms, the Rs 300 pension about Rs 165, and the Rs 500 pension about Rs 275. But this shameful government would rather spend nearly Rs 1.5 Cr every single

day on advertisements and lofty self-promotions!

“Between 2014-15 and 2024-25, the BJP Government spent a total of Rs 5,987.46 Cr on self-promotion in the form of advertisements,” he alleged.

The Congress chief alleged that while crores of elderly citizens are forced to survive on low pensions that cannot even cover basic medicines and food, the Modi government and the BJP continue to splurge on extravagant election campaigns, grand convoys, massive events, and nonstop publicity. “This cruel BJP model strips disadvantaged citizens of their economic dignity while spending extravagantly on political spectacle,” he said. MPOST

Panel to review SC/ST, Forest Rights Acts

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary committee has decided to undertake a detailed review of the implementation of key legislations aimed at protecting and empowering Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs), including the Prevention of Atrocities Act, 1989, and the Forest Rights Act, 2006.

The Committee on the Welfare of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes will examine how effectively the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act has been implemented and assess its impact on curbing atrocities against marginalised communities across the country. The panel is also expected to study challenges faced in enforcing the law and identify areas requiring policy intervention.

Apart from the atrocities law, the committee will review the status of implementation of the Forest Rights Act, 2006, which recognises the rights of forest-dwelling tribal communities over land and forest resources. The panel is likely to assess whether the benefits of the legislation are reaching intended beneficiaries and how state governments are carrying out the provisions of the Act.

According to a Lok Sabha Secretariat bulletin issued on Tuesday, the committee has selected several important issues related to SC/ST welfare for examination during 2026-27. One of the major subjects identified is reservation for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in the private sector, an long-debated issue in policy circles. The committee will also deliberate on matters related to SC/ST certificates, implementation of reservation policies in Central Public Sector Undertakings (CPSUs), and the execution of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives for SC/ST communities.

In addition, the panel will discuss the implementation of pre-matric, post-matric and overseas scholarship schemes run by various Union ministries for students belonging to SC and ST communities. MPOST

SC stays order on TVK MLA, terms HC ruling as ‘atrocious’

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed the Madras High Court order that had restrained TVK MLA R Sreenivasa Sethupathi from participating in the floor test in the Tamil Nadu assembly, saying such a directive under writ jurisdiction was “atrocious”.

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government in Tamil Nadu crossed the major hurdle on Wednesday, winning a confidence-boosting trust vote by a 144-22 margin amid a walkout by the principal opposition party DMK and a divided AIADMK whose one faction supported the C Joseph Vijay-led government.

“This is atrocious to say the least. The high court says the remedy is election petition but still entertains the Article 226

The high court says the remedy is election petition but still entertains the Article 226 petition, stated Apex Court

petition,” a bench of justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi observed while hearing the plea.

Article 226 of the Constitution empowers high courts to issue writs of various nature to do complete justice. However, any order with regard to cancellation of an elected candidate can only be passed on an election

petition filed by defeated candidate or a related party.

While issuing notice on Sethupathi’s plea challenging the high court’s May 12 interim order, the apex court also stayed the proceedings pending before the high court in the matter.

“In the meantime, the effect and operation of the impugned order shall remain stayed and further proceedings before the high court in pending writ petition shall also remain stayed,” the top court said.

Sethupathi had won the No.185 Tirupattur assembly constituency in Sivagan-gai district by a margin of a single vote against Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) leader and former minister KR Periakaruppan. MPOST

Assam Cabinet approves implementation of UCC, tribals to be outside its ambit

‘Decision aligns with the commitment we made during the elections’, says Sarma



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma chairs the first Cabinet meeting PTI

Key Points

» The draft of the UCC Bill will be laid before the assembly on May 26, the chief minister said at a press conference here after chairing the first Cabinet meeting of his second term as the head

of the government

» The UCC will primarily cover the four subjects -- minimum age of marriage, prohibition of polygamy, equal rights for daughters in parents’ property and matters relating to live-in relationships

exempted the tribal population from the purview of UCC. All rituals, traditions and customs practised by the people of Assam outside the scope of

UCC,” he said.

The UCC will deal with succession, marriage, live-in relationships and compulsory registration of marriage and

divorce, he added.

It will create a uniform set of laws for all residents -- excluding Scheduled Tribes and Adivasi communities -- and will replace various religion-based personal laws with a common legal framework to ensure equality and transparency, define core legal terms and recognise various customs and modern family structures, Sarma said.

The CM also stated that religious practices and rituals related to marriages will not fall within the purview of the UCC. The Cabinet also adopted several austerity measures in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s call for fuel conservation amid the prevailing West Asia crisis.

The measures include downsizing convoys of the governor, CM, ministers and government officials, reduction of government fuel consumption by 20 per cent and a six-month ban on procuring new cars or foreign items by the government. The other austerity measures include no official

or private foreign trips by ministers and officials except in the case of medical emergencies, no physical meetings or seminars for six months. The government will rent only electric vehicles, if required, and efforts to scrap 15-20-year-old vehicles will be expedited.

The Cabinet also adopted the BJP’s election manifesto as the guiding principle of governance for the next five years and will form the base of policy formulation in the state, Sarma said. “The decisive mandate received by the BJP-led NDA in the 2026 assembly elections is a public endorsement of the BJP’s ‘Sankalpa Patra’ which is a formal governance agenda committing the government to deliver 31 specific promises over the five-year term,” he said.

A Manifesto Implementation Cell (MIC) will be established in the Chief Minister’s Office to coordinate, monitor and report on the implementation of the promises made during the election and to address interdepartmental issues as they arise. AGENCIES

Nation Briefs

CM SAINI ROLLS OUT FUEL-SAVING MEASURES AFTER PM MODI’S APPEAL

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday said he has decided to use the minimum number of vehicles in his convoy and also mentioned about a series of other initiatives his government will take following Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s appeal for cutting down fuel consumption and spending more wisely. Saini also said ministers and officers of all departments will also ensure the use of limited vehicles during travel. Along with this, all ministers, MLAs, and officers are urged to organise the maximum number of meetings through virtual medium, he said. “In response to the call of the Hon’ble Prime Minister Shri @narendramodi ji, the Haryana government is moving forward with a resolve to save fuel and ensure the proper use of resources in the national interest,” Saini said.

CMS OF MEGHALAYA, MIZORAM DEPLORE KILLING OF 3 CHURCH LEADERS

SHILLONG/AIZAWL: The chief ministers of Meghalaya and Mizoram on Wednesday condemned the killing of Baptist church leaders in Manipur, terming the attack a “senseless act of violence” and calling for immediate action to bring the perpetrators to justice. Mizoram’s main opposition, the Mizo National Front (MNF), also deplored the killing in the neighbouring state’s Kangpokpi district and demanded strict punishment for the culprits. Three church leaders were shot dead and four others injured in an attack by suspected militants in Manipur’s Kangpokpi district.

— UAE IS FOURTH LARGEST EXPORTER OF CRUDE OIL TO INDIA —

As West Asia crisis deepens, Modi begins Gulf outreach

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday underlined Prime Minister Narendra Modi's upcoming visit to the United Arab Emirates on May 15 is indicative of the deep strategic significance of India-UAE relations in nearly ten years.

The visit will take place at a time of growing geo-political tension and instability in the global energy markets amid ongoing tensions in West Asia, disruptions in the area of maritime security around the Strait of Hormuz, and growing tensions for energy resources.

While travelling to the United Arab Emirates during a period of escalating geopolitical unrest and volatility in the world energy markets, due to persistent conflicts in West Asia, turmoil in maritime security in the Strait of Hormuz, and growing competition for energy resources.

As per Additional Secretary (Gulf) Aseem Mahajan, far from being just another diplomatic mission, the trip will serve to consolidate what has emerged into one of India's most significant alliances in the Gulf – an

Highlights

» PM's UAE visit is taking place following the UAE's decision to withdraw from the OPEC+ group

» The energy collaboration between the two countries, has increased significantly in the recent past

alliance that covers a wide range of areas from energy security to renewable energy and much more. Speaking to the media persons here in New Delhi, before the PM's impending visit, the senior foreign official underscored the pivotal role played by the UAE in India's energy strategy.

He stated that currently, the UAE is the fourth largest exporter of crude oil to India, contributing to almost 11 per cent of India's total crude oil imports. Considering the volatility and disruption in global supply chains due to conflicts and geopolitics, the initiative of India to engage in long-term energy deals with reliable partners like UAE becomes more critical.

In a very interesting turn of events, the PM's UAE visit is taking place following the UAE's decision to withdraw from the OPEC+ group. The decision is of interest to the world's top

importers of energy resources, such as India, and analysts suggest that the changing dynamics in the sphere of energy may well lead to further agreements with Abu Dhabi on long-term cooperation. Furthermore, govt officials stressed that PM Modi's visit will carry a "very concrete agenda" involving such topics as trade, technology, energy cooperation and business.

The energy collaboration between the two countries has increased significantly in the recent past, especially in liquefied natural gas (LNG), Mahajan underlined. According to him, Indian state-owned companies and ADNOC have made long-term contracts for 4.5 million metric tons per annum (MMTPA) of LNG supply to India. The agreements have been reached between Indian energy giants IOCL, GAIL and HPCL. Also, IOCL and GAIL have signed a contract with ADNOC

in February 2024 for a supply of one and 0.5 MMTPA of LNG, respectively, while IOCL signed another long-term contract with the company in September 2024.

Furthermore, during the UAE president's visit to India in January, this year, HPCL signed a ten-year deal with ADNOC Gas for 0.5 MMTPA of LNG starting from 2028. Through these contracts, India has emerged as the top importer of LNG from the UAE.

Similarly, the UAE continues to be the largest supplier of LPG to India, accounting for almost 40 per cent of the country's total demand for the commodity.

At the same time, the UAE has become the second-largest market for petroleum, oil and lubricant shipments from Indian refineries, reflecting the growing mutual dependency in energy trade. The Centre also emphasised that the partnership of India and the UAE, has transcended beyond the buyer-seller framework. India's leading private firms have invested in the exploration of energy resources in the UAE, indicating a paradigm shift in the nation's energy engagement abroad.

Manipur: Suspected militants kill 3 church leaders, injure 4

'A civilian was gunned down, his wife wounded in Noney district'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Takeaways

» Kangpokpi incident happened at a place between Kotzim and Kotlen villages when members of the Thadou Baptist Association were returning from Churachandpur

» The second incident occurred at a place between Jouzangtek and Nungsai villages in Noney district around 8 pm

IMPHAL: In fresh violence in Manipur on Wednesday, suspected militants shot three church leaders dead and injured four others in Kangpokpi district, while a civilian was gunned down and his wife wounded in Noney district, officials said.

The Kangpokpi incident happened in the morning hours at a place between Kotzim and Kotlen villages when members of the Thadou Baptist Association (TBA) were returning from Churachandpur after attending a religious congregation.

The second incident occurred at a place between Jouzangtek and Nungsai villages in Noney district around 8 pm.

After the Kangpokpi ambush, Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh stated that such "senseless acts of violence" against innocent civilians threaten peace in Manipur which has been rocked by ethnic violence since 2023.

Chief Ministers of Mizoram and Manipur condemned the killing of church leaders and sought immediate arrest of the

tified as Reverend Kaigoulen and Pastor Paogoulen, they said.

The chief minister said three of those injured were admitted to the Shija Hospitals and Research Institute in Imphal.

He, along with Deputy Chief Minister Losii Dikho, Home Minister Govindas Komthoujam, visited the injured in the hospital.

"The state government will bear all medical expenses for the injured, and I have directed the authorities to ensure they receive the highest standard of care," Singh said in a statement.

"This act of violence is deeply troubling and devastating not only for the families but for the entire state, as it disrupts our path to peace. Our state is gradually moving towards peace; therefore, actions that undermine this collective effort of our people to restore normalcy are unacceptable," he said.

Stressing that there is no justification in any society for acts of terrorism, the CM said the people of the entire state stand together against such an act of terror.

culprits.

Following the killings, a total shutdown was imposed in Kangpokpi district where Kukis are in the majority.

A forum of Naga legislators and a Kuki organisation also deplored the killings, while a Meitei group rejected allegations from some quarters that it was behind the ambush.

Police said suspected militants ambushed the two vehicles in which the church leaders were travelling.

Among those killed was Reverend V Sithour, a former general secretary of the Manipur Baptist Convention. The other two deceased were iden-

Punjab CM meets Agri minister Chouhan, shares several state concerns

Seeks his intervention for de-notification of certain hybrid paddy seeds

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday called upon Union Agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and sought his intervention for the de-notification of certain hybrid paddy seeds to ensure smooth procurement and lifting operations in Punjab during the forthcoming Kharif season, while raising a series of critical issues concerning the state's farmers before the Centre.

During the crucial meeting in Delhi, CM Mann secured assurances on uninterrupted fertiliser supply and groundwater conservation, demanded Punjab's representation in the Central Seed Committee, and pressed for wheat seed subsidy allocation for 2026-27.

Emphasising that Punjab's farmers had successfully achieved the Centre's target of 125 lakh metric tonnes of wheat production, CM Mann asserted that the Punjab government is now aggressively promoting crop diversification through maize, pulses, oilseeds, sunflower and bajra to reduce dependence on paddy cultivation, conserve rapidly depleting groundwater reserves and pull Punjab out of the dangerous



dark zone crisis threatening the state's agrarian future.

During the meeting with the Union minister, Mann also strongly pitched for Punjab's representation in the Central Seed Committee under the proposed Seed Bill 2025 and sought greater support from the Centre for crop diversification and agricultural reforms in the state.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Mann on Wednesday secured major assurances from the Centre for completion of several long-pending highway and flyover projects in Punjab after a crucial meeting with Union Road Transport and Highways minister Nitin Gadkari, with stalled infrastructure works at Makhu, Adampur and Bhanigarh set to move forward and key road corridors across the state likely to witness large-scale expansion and four-laning.

BJP sweeps Haryana municipal corporation polls

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: With the sweeping win of BJP candidate Sham Lal Bansal by 35,735 votes and MC elections further highlighting the saffron party's strong hold in urban pockets of Haryana it definitely revealed the poor planning and communication in the political strategy of Haryana Congress.

BJP won 17 of 20 wards and the massive margin in the mayoral underlined the

incline of urban voters in Panchkula towards governance visibility and political stability rather than traditional Opposition narratives.

BJP mayor candidate Sham Lal Bansal got 66,593 votes while Congress's Sudha Bhardwaj got 30,856.

Political luminaries believe that the Congress struggled to build a convincing campaign that focussed on city-related issues and its development.

The saffron party's time and again campaigned about

roads, sewerage, drainage, sanitation and infrastructure while the Congress continued to merely react. The BJP was yet again successful in building a narrative of a party that plans and executes consistently while Congress miserably failed to create such an image.

Political experts also believe that the appropriate alchemy of mobilisation of workers at booth level, meticulous planning and robust organisational structure led

to BJP's landslide victory.

Meanwhile, the Congress party continued to raise doubt on the working of the elections machinery and alleged irregularities.

Also, the city witnessed a poor voter turn out at 53.4 per cent. According to information, the voter turn out was better in rural belts, villages bad colonies while urban wards witnessed lesser turn out.

As per political analyst the results indicate dominance of

BJP among urban voters in Haryana.

As the counting progressed on May 13 indicating a sweeping win for the BJP candidates, it became clear that the people still have faith in BJP leadership despite anti-incumbency.

The notable successes in Sonipat, Ambala, and Panchkula, along with widespread support across other municipal bodies, indicates that the public has endorsed a positive and result-oriented approach to governance.

BJP launches 'Mission UP 2027'

Bets bigger on booth-level micro management

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: After drawing confidence from its recent electoral performance in West Bengal and Assam, the Bharatiya Janata Party has launched an aggressive organisational push in Uttar Pradesh for the 2027 Assembly elections, banking heavily on booth-level micro-management that party strategists believe remains the backbone of electoral success.

The party has decided to appoint nearly 1.76 lakh "booth palaks" across Uttar Pradesh and activate its grassroots machinery almost two years before the Assembly polls.

The move comes days after the expansion of the Yogi Adityanath cabinet and is being seen as part of a broader attempt to tighten both governance and



organisation simultaneously ahead of the next electoral battle.

A high-level meeting of presidents of all 98 organisational districts of the BJP was held at the party's state headquarters in Lucknow on Tuesday under the leadership of state BJP president Pankaj Chaudhary and state general secretary (organisation) Dharampal Singh.

According to party sources, district chiefs were instructed to replicate the Bengal election model in Uttar Pradesh with a renewed focus on booth committees, panna pramukhs, shakti kendras and hyper-local polit-

ical campaigns. The BJP aims to assess all 1,62,459 Assembly booths in the state, including 27,633 shakti kendras spread across 1,918 mandals, within the next month.

The exercise will also cover nearly 14,000 new booths created after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Party leaders directed district units to immediately constitute booth committees and appoint booth presidents and booth caretakers for these newly added polling stations.

Under the proposed structure, booth palaks (co-ordinators) will maintain regular contact with influential voters in their booth areas, coordinate with local committee members and monitor political activities and voter trends at the grassroots level.

Khera faces marathon questioning in Guwahati

In cases filed by Assam CM's wife

OUR CORRESPONDENT



GUWAHATI: Congress leader Pawan Khera was questioned for more than 10 hours on Wednesday by the Assam Police Crime Branch in connection with cases filed by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife Riniki Bhuyan Sharma.

Khera said he was asked to appear again before the crime branch on Thursday morning.

The cases were filed after Khera alleged that Sharma possessed multiple passports and undisclosed properties abroad.

Speaking to reporters after the questioning, Khera said he was cooperating with the investigation.

"I am a law-abiding citizen. It is my duty to cooperate as there is a Constitution and I will abide by it," he said.

"I have been called again at 9.30 am on Thursday, and I will come. I have been cooperating with police and will continue to do so," he added.

Asked about the lengthy questioning, Khera declined to comment. Earlier in the day, before entering the crime branch office, Khera said



Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw during a press conference on Cabinet decisions, in New Delhi, Wednesday PFI

Maritime Heritage Complex (NHMC)," according to an official statement.

"Connecting Ahmedabad with Dholera will cut down passenger travel time, enabling comfortable daily commuting and same-day return trips.

This semi-high-speed railway

would not only bring two cities closer but also bring the people living hundreds of kilometers away closer to each other," it said.

Dholera Special Investment Region (DSIR) in Gujarat is a greenfield industrial smart city, envisioned as a global hub for manufacturing, innovation, and urban living.

Addressing mediapersons, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the Ahmedabad-Dholera corridor is part of the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor and that the semi-high-speed rail line will boost development across the region.

He said the train will have a design speed of 220 kmph and an operational speed of 200 kmph.

Nation Briefs

MAN KILLS FATHER AFTER DRUNKEN ALTERCATION IN JHARKHAND'S PAKUR

PAKUR: A 40-year-old man allegedly killed his father following an altercation while both were drinking in Jharkhand's Pakur district, police said on Wednesday. The incident took place on Tuesday night in Kittajhor in the Town police station area, they said. The accused, identified as Diwakar Sardar, allegedly attacked his father, Anup Sardar (65), with a sickle after an altercation broke out between them while they were consuming country-made liquor at their house, police said. "In a fit of rage, the accused attacked his father with a sickle, causing severe injuries. The victim died on the spot due to excessive bleeding," Town police station's officer-in-charge Anil Gupta said.

UP ROLLS OUT 'VISIT MY STATE' ACTION PLAN WITH FREE MUSEUM ENTRY

LUCKNOW: Positioning the current global uncertainty as an opportunity, Uttar Pradesh Tourism has moved swiftly to operationalise the 'Visit My State' campaign, announcing free entry to state-run museums for children and families for the next two months, alongside curated summer travel circuits, accommodation discounts and destination-specific packages aimed at keeping travellers within the state during the vacation season. The action plan was finalised at a high-level meeting chaired by Tourism and Culture Minister Jaiveer Singh on Wednesday, following Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's directions issued a day earlier in line with PM Narendra Modi's call to prioritise domestic travel and reduce non-essential overseas spending.

NIA arrests wanted narco-terrorist after extradition from Portugal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday arrested wanted narco-terrorist Iqbal Singh alias Shera after successfully securing his extradition from Portugal.

He was taken into custody by an NIA team at the Delhi airport immediately after he arrived from Portugal, to where he had absconded in 2020. His successful extradition and arrest come as a major shot in the arm for the NIAs' fight against Pakistan-backed narco and cross-border terrorism, officials said.

During the investigation, the NIA found Shera to be a key conspirator and handler of an India-based narco-terror module engaged in smuggling heroin from Pakistan.

A native of Punjab's Amritsar, Shera had allegedly masterminded a conspiracy to smuggle narcotics from Pakistan into the border state, the probe agency said.

Himachal Governor cuts down travels, expenses

Aims at reducing fuel consumption and promoting austerity

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: In a significant and symbolic gesture of solidarity Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Thursday announced a comprehensive set of measures at Raj Bhavan aimed at reducing fuel consumption, promoting austerity, and positioning Himachal Pradesh as a model state in India's collective response to global energy.

Governor has announced that Raj Bhavan will henceforth function as a designated "Fuel Conservation Zone." He announced that Lok Bhavan will observe "Petrol-Free Sundays" — with no official vehicle using a single litre of imported fuel on Sundays. All Sunday official engagements will be conducted through video conferencing or consolidated travel arrangements

Gupta has directed that the size of all his official convoys be reduced with immediate effect — a decisive and visible step that signals that the constitutional head of the

Key Points

» Governor has announced that Raj Bhavan will henceforth function as a designated 'Fuel Conservation Zone'

» Gupta has directed that the size of all his official convoys be reduced with immediate effect

state is prepared to lead by personal example even in matters of operational comfort. All non-essential official meetings will henceforth be conducted through video conferencing, eliminating unnecessary road travel. Official events and functions will be consolidated to further reduce vehicle movement. All government departments have been directed to adopt strict austerity measures and minimise fuel expenditure with immediate effect.

Governor has declared that he will not use the state government helicopter for any official engagements until the West

Asia crisis subsides and global fuel prices stabilise. "When the nation is being called upon to conserve every drop of fuel, it would be inappropriate for me to use the most fuel-intensive mode of official transport available," the Gupta said.

As the Chancellor of all State Universities of Himachal Pradesh, Governor Gupta made a special appeal to Vice Chancellors across the state to institutionalise fuel and energy conservation within their respective campuses immediately. He asked the Vice Chancellors to issue formal advisories to faculty, staff, and students promoting carpooling, cycling, and use of public transport for daily commute. He called upon students — as the most energetic and influential section of society — to become ambassadors of the fuel conservation movement in their colleges, hostels, and home communities. "Our universities must not merely teach conservation as a subject — they must practise it as a culture," the Governor said.



EDITORIAL

PRICE OF GOLD OBSESSION?

India's decision to sharply raise import duty on gold from 6 per cent to 15 per cent reflects the anxiety of an economy navigating turbulent global conditions. With crude oil prices elevated due to the continuing conflict in West Asia, and the import bill for fertilisers and food also rising, New Delhi has chosen a familiar path: discouraging non-essential imports to protect foreign exchange reserves and support a weakening rupee. Economically, the logic is understandable. Politically, too, it signals prudence at a time when external vulnerabilities are mounting. Yet history suggests that gold is not an easy commodity to regulate through taxation alone.

India's relationship with gold is unlike that of most economies. Gold here is not merely an investment instrument or a luxury purchase. It is embedded in social customs, family security, weddings, inheritance, and informal savings. This deep cultural attachment explains why Indian households collectively hold nearly 30,000 tonnes of gold — among the largest private reserves in the world. Even when prices surge, demand rarely disappears entirely. Instead, buyers briefly postpone purchases, shift to lighter jewellery, or turn to informal channels. That is why repeated duty hikes over the years have reduced import volumes only marginally while the overall import bill has remained stubbornly high because of elevated international prices.

The latest increase is therefore unlikely to produce dramatic macroeconomic relief. Gold prices in Delhi have already jumped sharply following the announcement, and the impact will soon be reflected in retail inflation data. More importantly, the current account deficit may not narrow meaningfully because even lower import volumes would still arrive at significantly higher global prices. Meanwhile, the rupee continues to remain under pressure against the dollar. In effect, the government is attempting to manage symptoms of a larger global economic stress rather than the root cause itself.

There is also an old danger that returns every time duties are raised steeply: smuggling. India has witnessed this repeatedly in earlier decades. Higher domestic prices create lucrative opportunities for illegal syndicates operating through land borders, airports, and maritime routes. A widening gap between international and domestic prices often fuels a parallel economy that hurts legitimate jewellers while strengthening criminal networks. Excessive taxation on a product with persistent cultural demand can unintentionally undermine the very regulatory objectives it seeks to achieve.

The government has previously attempted more sophisticated solutions. The Gold Monetisation Scheme sought to mobilise idle household gold and reduce dependence on imports, while Sovereign Gold Bonds encouraged digital ownership instead of physical purchases. Neither initiative fully transformed consumer behaviour. The monetisation scheme struggled because Indians remain emotionally attached to physical gold, while sovereign bonds became financially expensive for the government. Their discontinuation underlines an uncomfortable reality: policy innovation alone cannot easily alter deeply rooted social habits.

Still, the present duty hike should not be dismissed entirely. In times of economic uncertainty, governments are often compelled to take short-term defensive measures. But the larger lesson is that India cannot tax its way out of gold dependence. Long-term stability will require stronger domestic financial instruments, deeper trust in formal savings systems, lower inflation volatility, and sustained economic confidence among households. Until then, gold will continue to shine not just as a metal, but as India's preferred shield against uncertainty.

NEXUS OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND A FORMER CIVIL SERVANT

In an era of policy slogans, Chaitanya offers a working model of grassroots empowerment rooted in dignity, participation and sustainability

Beyond Welfare, Towards Development

For over three decades, Chaitanya has shown how women-led institutions can transform rural economies through trust, finance and collective strength

The occasion was an event organised by the Pune City Chapter of Nexus of Good. The objective of the City Chapter was to provide a platform to present the inspiring work being done by entities in the region. One of the three organisations that gave presentations to showcase the good work they are doing in the field was Chaitanya. They demonstrated how they were transforming the lives of women in rural areas by empowering them. There are many such organisations in the country engaged in this sort of activity, but Chaitanya was a bit different.

Chaitanya is a not-for-profit organisation established in 1993, working extensively in rural Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh to empower women through Self-Help Groups (SHGs), federations, and community-led development processes. Over three decades, Chaitanya has built a strong grassroots presence, reaching over 1.4 lakh women through more than 14,000 SHGs and promoting 46 federations that are largely self-managed and financially sustainable.

It partnered with both public sector commercial banks and foreign banks to enable access to finance for 1.4 lakh women across 18 districts in the two states. Chaitanya has also trained over 100 Self-Help Promoting Institutions and partnered with government programmes such as IFAD-supported Tejaswini and NRLM across multiple states.

In recognition of its contributions to SHG federations, NABARD, on the occasion of the silver jubilee celebration marking 25 years of the SHG programme, felicitated Chaitanya through the then Finance Minister, Mr Arun Jaitley, in 2017. That same year, in December, Chaitanya was honoured as the Best Self-Help Promoting Institution at the Inclusive Finance India Summit, an event organised by ACCESS and HSBC, and awarded by NITI Aayog, DFID, banks, and NABARD. In 2025, Chaitanya received the Elaben Memorial Award for the most gender-inclusive SHG Promoting Institution from Sadhan.

To strengthen its organisational capacity, Chaitanya focused on advocacy, bringing its learnings to the attention of state and national governments for implementation. Building



Chaitanya's work across states demonstrates how women-led institutions can become engines of social and economic change

consensus for development and change at the government level required greater investment in time and human resources. Integration of technology into community-based people's institutions has been at the core of the Chaitanya programme for the last seven years, with the development of the Microlekha software, currently handling the financial transactions of 1.4 million SHG members; the Astitva application to record cases of gender-based violence (GBV); as well as an e-learning course on SHG and federation management.

Chaitanya's integrated approach—combining institution building, livelihoods, financial inclusion, and gender justice—has made it a recognised resource organisation for sustainable, women-led rural development.

It partnered with both public sector commercial banks — Bank of Maharashtra has given a cash credit limit of Rs 1.5 crore to federations promoted by Chaitanya — ICICI Bank, and foreign bank Rabobank to enable access to finance for 1.4 lakh women across 18 districts in the two states. Chaitanya has also trained over 100 Self-Help Promoting Institutions and partnered with government pro-

grammes such as IFAD-supported Tejaswini and NRLM across multiple states.

Chaitanya was a resource partner of MAVIM from 2010 to 2015 for the Tejaswini programme, and the technical agency promoted by Chaitanya is currently a partner of IFAD to support MAVIM-promoted federations in entering all financial data into the Microlekha software developed by it.

Chaitanya strengthened the financial management systems and processes of 16 federations located in the tribal districts of Barwani and Shahdol in Madhya Pradesh in partnership with the Madhya Pradesh State Rural Livelihood Mission. The Executive Director of Chaitanya developed the standard operating manual on financial management of SHG federations for the National Rural Livelihood Mission. It also developed a digitised e-learning course on the management of SHGs and federations in collaboration with the Jharkhand SRLM and the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS). More than 150 students were trained in Jharkhand. A total of four courses have been launched by Chaitanya in partnership with TISS.

With the support of IWWAGE and subsequently the Gates Foundation (BMGF), Chaitanya initiated work to address gender-based violence in Chhattisgarh in partnership with Bihaan (CGSRLM). It trained over 1,750 community women leaders (Jaankars) to provide counselling and support services, while also establishing Gender Resource Centres in partnership with state governments. It is currently leading the work on Gender Resource Centres in the state and is directly supporting 16 GRCs across seven districts. The gender Jaankars are also providing counselling services in 25 police stations across the three states. Police headquarters in Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh have issued orders to district police superintendents to seek the help of Jaankar women trained by Chaitanya to support women facing domestic violence.

Integration of technology into community-based people's institutions has been at the core of the Chaitanya programme for the last seven years, with the development of the Microlekha software, currently handling the financial transactions of 1.4 million SHG members, including MAVIM and Hindustan Zinc Limited.

The Astitva application has been developed to record cases of GBV. The e-learning course on SHG and federation management, developed jointly with TISS, was supported by the Jharkhand State Livelihood Promotion Society, and a total of five batches have been completed. Dr Shalini Bhagat, Director, TISS, distributed certificates during one of the convocations in Ranchi.

Chaitanya's integrated approach—combining institution building, livelihoods, financial inclusion, and gender justice—has made it a recognised resource organisation for sustainable, women-led rural development. It presents a wonderful example of Nexus of Good, a model that can be replicated and scaled through public-private partnerships. They have already demonstrated that it can happen despite an adverse set of circumstances. Chaitanya is already scaling up what it has achieved, but it is now for others to learn from what has already been accomplished and take it forward.

Views expressed are personal

UNFOLDING CRISIS



MAXIM V RYZHENKOV

THE WRITER IS THE MINISTER OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS OF THE REPUBLIC OF BELARUS

Against the backdrop of prolonged wars and shifting alliances, calls for a region-led security framework are gaining visibility across the continent

Last year, in a piece on the Eurasian Charter of Diversity and Multipolarity in the XXI Century, I argued that external interference in the affairs of Eurasian countries has consistently prevented their successful and independent development.

The current conflict in the Middle East has tragically and irrefutably confirmed this observation. This conflict is not merely another regional tragedy. It is the latest violent proof that external actors cannot manage Eurasian security. Once again, we have witnessed the familiar pattern: unilateral intervention in violation of international law, disregard for local realities, attempts to pit neighbours against each other, and the pursuit of strategic interests that have nothing to do with the well-being of the nations caught in the crossfire. The result, as always, is more death, more displacement, and a deeper erosion of any hope for regional stability.

Regrettably, the architects of these policies have not learned the lessons of the Balkans, Iraq, Afghanistan, or Ukraine. They continue to believe that military force, unilateral sanctions, and political manipulation can reshape Eurasia according to their own blueprints. And every time they fail, but only after causing immense suffering to the people on our continent.

For Eurasian countries, the message could not be clearer. We cannot rely on external guardians to provide our security. We cannot wait for a "benign international liberal order" to return, because such an order never truly existed in practice — it was never liberal, it was hegemonic. And we certainly cannot afford to remain passive while others attempt to determine the future of our continent. What we need — urgently — is our own solution, forged by us and for us. We need Eurasian solutions to Eurasian problems.

The Eurasian Charter: An Indigenous Solution Based on Indivisible Security

The core lesson of the current Middle East conflict, as well as of every other failed external intervention in Eurasia over the past three decades, is this: only an indigenous, inclusive, and consensus-based security architecture can work. The CSCE succeeded during the Cold War precisely because it was a genuine forum for dialogue between the two camps that respected each other's existence. The OSCE failing when it became an instrument for

Why Eurasia Cannot Wait

Eurasian nations must build a shared security framework rooted in cooperation, regional balance and freedom from external geopolitical intervention



Eurasia needs a new security architecture — one based on indivisible security, mutual respect and genuine partnership

one group of participating states to impose its will on others. The so-called US-led "liberal order" failed because it was never liberal — it was hegemonic.

What Eurasia needs instead is a new approach, grounded in the principle that has been invoked since the 1975 Helsinki Final Act but never truly implemented: the indivisibility of security. No country in Eurasia should seek its own security at the expense of others. No external power should be allowed to play one Eurasian state against another. And no regional conflict should be treated as an opportunity for geopolitical gain.

This is precisely what the Eurasian Charter of Diversity and Multipolarity in the XXI Century is supposed to offer.

As I argued in my piece from 2025, the Charter would not be directed against any country or groups of states. It is envisaged as a constructive, indigenous, collective, inclusive, and comprehensive effort. It will seek to establish a pan-Eurasian security architecture based on the norms and principles of the United Nations Charter. It will cover not only security, but also economic cooperation, humanitarian exchanges, and civilizational dialogue. It will welcome all Eurasian states, from Lisbon to Manila, in principle.

At the heart of the Charter will lie the principle of indivisible security — present in the Helsinki pre-

amble but never front and center. This time, it must be. But we must go beyond invocation. The Charter should operationalise indivisible security through concrete commitments: mandatory consultation on military alignments, transparency regarding foreign military infrastructure, institutional dispute resolution, and limits on unilateral coercive measures.

These should be the points for negotiation. They should translate the principle of indivisible security from a noble slogan into an operational framework.

As a result, no Eurasian country should feel threatened by another's legitimate security arrangements. No conflict in Eurasia should be resolved by force or by external diktat. And no country should be forced to choose between competing blocs.

The Charter will not be a vague declaration. It is intended to be a practical framework for action — a geostrategy for our supercontinent, covering security, economics, technology, culture, and more. To that end, we envision the Charter establishing some specific institutions that do not overlap with numerous existing Eurasian structures. Such new institutions may include, among others, a Conference on Security and Cooperation in Eurasia, a small secretariat based in a neutral venue, a dispute resolution mechanism, and regular confidence-building exercises involving military-to-military

dialogue. These ideas should be negotiated. The Charter should be a declaration with teeth.

From Discussion to Action

For nearly three years, the idea of the Eurasian Charter has been discussed in international forums, bilateral consultations and academic publications. The concept has attracted growing interest, and many Eurasian states have expressed support in principle. But discussion, however valuable, is not enough.

The Republic of Belarus and the Russian Federation, as co-sponsors of the initiative, have prepared a concrete roadmap to move from discussion to formal negotiation. That roadmap is set out in a non-paper that has been shared with our Eurasian partners. We propose launching formal negotiations during the 81st session of the UN General Assembly in September 2026, with the goal of adopting the Charter by 2027.

We understand that some may view the Charter with scepticism. Some may fear that it is directed against them. They may believe that their existing alliances and partnerships are sufficient. Others may simply be waiting to see how the process unfolds.

To these hesitations, I would like to offer three observations.

First, the Charter is not directed against anyone. It is open to all. Your participation is not a betrayal of any existing commitment — it is an investment in a more stable and pre-

dictable Eurasian order. The European Union, NATO members, and other Western-aligned states are welcome to come to the table in good faith — as equal participants, not instructors.

Second, the external conditions that have supported European prosperity and security are rapidly changing. The United States is deprecating Europe, as is affirmed in its 2025 National Security Strategy. The era of unlimited free trade and cheap resources is over. Europe's demographic, economic, and migratory challenges are mounting. No external power will save Europe from these trends. But cooperative action within Eurasia surely will.

Third, and most importantly, the cost of non-participation is growing by the day. Non-participation carries a different cost: the loss of a voice in shaping the rules that will govern this continent for decades. Every state that sits at the table helps write the final text. Every state that stays away accepts rules written by others. We say this as a fact of diplomatic life. If you choose to stand outside the emerging Eurasian order, you will not be able to stop it. You will simply forfeit your seat at the table while others shape the future of the continent where you live.

We have seen what indigenous cooperation can achieve. The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's quiet containment of border tensions in Central Asia, ASEAN's resilience despite great-power competition, the Collective Security Treaty Organisation's rapid consultations during the 2022 crisis in Kazakhstan — these are not perfect models. But they are ours. The Charter seeks to scale these lessons continent-wide, learning from both the successes and the failures of every Eurasian security experiment.

The time for discussion has passed. The time for hesitation has passed. The events of 2026 have sounded an alarm that no responsible country can ignore.

Eurasia needs a new security architecture — one based on indivisible security, mutual respect, and genuine partnership. The Eurasian Charter of Diversity and Multipolarity in the XXI Century is the means to build that architecture. And September 2026 in New York is the moment to begin.

I call upon all Eurasian states to join us in launching this historic process. Let us prove that we can shape our own destiny.

Views expressed are personal

TRUMP WAS THE LAST US PRESIDENT TO VISIT CHINA IN 2017

Trump gets rousing reception in Beijing on arrival for talks with Xi

BEIJING: US President Donald Trump landed in Beijing for a high-stakes two day visit for talks with his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping on a host of issues, including tariffs, the competition over tech, the Iran war and Taiwan.

Trump was welcomed by Chinese Vice President Han Zheng at the airport, a rare honour that broke with usual diplomatic protocol. Trump was the last US president to visit China in 2017.

By deputing Vice President Han to receive Trump, China sent a message about the importance it attached to his visit, observers said. There was also a brass band playing as Chinese military personnel presented a guard of honour as Trump descended the steps of his plane.

He was also greeted by 300 Chinese youth dressed in blue and white uniforms and waving



US President Donald Trump being greeted by China's Vice President Han Zheng as he arrives on Air Force One on Wednesday

AP/PTI

Chinese and American flags in unison, chanting in Chinese, "Welcome, welcome! Warm welcome!"

Trump briefly paused to listen to the flag-waving youth and moved to get into his limousine, The Big Beast, flown from Washington. The highway route leaving the airport was decorated with American and

Chinese flags. Skyscrapers were lit up with Chinese characters meaning "Beijing Welcome."

Trump's son Eric and his daughter-in-law Lara, as well as Tesla chief Elon Musk, disembarked from Air Force One along with Trump. Accompanying Trump on his trip to China are some of the US's top business and tech leaders.

Highlights

» Trump briefly paused to listen to the flag-waving youth and moved to get into his limousine

» The highway route leaving the airport was decorated with American and Chinese flags. Skyscrapers were lit up with Chinese characters meaning "Beijing Welcome"

and help bring the People's Republic to an even higher level," Trump said in a post on social media.

Trump said that it will be his "very first request" when he meets the Chinese leader, BBC reported.

"I have never seen or heard of any idea that would be more beneficial to our incredible Countries," he said.

The last-minute addition of Nvidia's Jensen Huang to Trump's delegation was regarded as significant.

China is bargaining for semiconductor chips for its AI tech development, while the US wants the rare-earth minerals used for manufacturing mobile phones and aircraft jets.

Ahead of Trump's arrival, Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng and Scott Bessent completed the final round of trade negotiations in South Korea, details of which are not known. AGENCIES

Russia presses its barrages of Kyiv as Trump talks of possible peace

KYIV: More than 100 Russian drones targeted areas of Ukraine on Wednesday, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, hours after another barrage of civilian areas killed at least eight people.

"Russia continues its strikes and is doing so brazenly — deliberately targeting our railway infrastructure and civilian sites in our cities," Zelenskyy said in a post on X.

Moscow's attacks on its neighbour are unrelenting, even as Ukraine is emboldened by its recent military accomplishments and as US President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin said — without providing evidence — that the 4-year-old war could be approaching an end.

The overnight strikes targeted Ukraine's residential and railway infrastructure in the central Dnipro and north-eastern Kharkiv regions, port



Russian President Vladimir Putin

infrastructure in the southern Odesa region, and energy facilities in the central Poltava region, according to Zelenskyy. On Tuesday, he said, 14 regions came under attack throughout the day.

Putin said in a speech last weekend that his invasion of Ukraine is possibly "coming to an end." Neither leader elaborated on what persuaded them

Israeli drone strikes in Lebanon kill 12, including 2 children

BEIRUT: Israeli airstrikes Wednesday struck seven vehicles in Lebanon — three of them on the main highway just south of Beirut — killing 12 people including a woman and her two children, the Lebanese Health Ministry said.

The Israeli military said it struck Hezbollah infrastructure in several areas in southern Lebanon, hours after telling residents of six southern villages to evacuate. Lebanon and Israel are scheduled to hold another round of direct talks in Washington on Thursday as the Trump administration pushes for a breakthrough between the two neighbours that have been in a state of war since Israel was created in 1948.

The Health Ministry confirmed the seven airstrikes on vehicles, but didn't provide full details of the number of people in each vehicle. Two of Wednesday's drone attacks hit a highway linking Beirut with the southern port city of Sidon, while a third struck the town of Saadiyat near the busy freeway, the state-run National news agency said. The Health Ministry



Women grieve during a funeral procession

AP/PTI

A fourth strike took place in the early afternoon near the northern entrance of Sidon

istry said those strikes killed eight people in total, including the mother and children.

A fourth strike took place in the early afternoon near the northern entrance of Sidon, leaving one per on dead and another wounded, the ministry

said. It added that three other drone strikes on cars deeper in southern Lebanon killed three people. An Associated Press photographer saw the bodies of three people killed in two of the strikes near the coastal towns of Barja and Jiyeh.

In southern Lebanon, Israeli airstrikes were reported in various towns and villages while Hezbollah claimed that it launched additional attacks on Israel as both sides keep exchanging fire despite a US-brokered ceasefire on April 17. AGENCIES

Russia places UK former minister on wanted list

LONDON: Russia has placed British former defence minister Ben Wallace on a wanted list in connection with an unspecified criminal investigation, state media said on Wednesday, citing the Russian Interior Ministry's database.

Wallace served as the UK's defence minister from before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 until August 2023, since when he has continued to advocate for boosting military support for Kyiv and condemned Russian aggression. The state media reports did not give further details on the case against him.

Commenting on the move, Wallace said: "I am not surprised by this latest Russian stunt at a time when the Kremlin is failing at home and abroad." "The whole world knows that Russia illegally invaded Ukraine four years ago," he said by email, accusing

Ben Wallace served as the UK's defence minister from before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 until Aug 2023

the Kremlin of "sending thousands of young Russian men to their deaths all for the sake of Putin's ego." Last October, a regional Russian lawmaker called for Wallace to be put on Russia's international wanted list over comments he made at the Warsaw Security Forum about Crimea, which Russia annexed from Ukraine in 2014.

Speaking at the forum in September, Wallace had recommended helping Ukraine carry out a military strike on the bridge which links southern Russia to Crimea. AGENCIES

Iranian oil transfers near its waters exploit maritime loophole: Malaysia

KUALA LUMPUR: Malaysia's maritime agency says Iranian-linked tankers are exploiting "jurisdictional gaps" to conduct ship-to-ship transfers of sanctioned oil near its waters, rejecting allegations that authorities ignored a long-running trade allowing Iran to evade US sanctions.

US-based advocacy group United Against Nuclear Iran (UANI) and shipping industry observers say waters near Malaysia's southern Johor state have become a key hub for ship-to-ship transfers involving Iran's "shadow fleet" — aging tankers that often operate with disabled tracking systems, false identities and opaque ownership structures to conceal the origins of crude bound largely for China. The area, known as the

Eastern Outer Port Limits, or EOPL, in the South China Sea is about 70 km (45 miles) off Johor. It lies along one of the world's busiest maritime trade routes and is about halfway between Iran and China, which buys about 90% of Iranian oil. US officials have previously said Iranian oil exports rely heavily on service providers and ship-to-ship transfers operating near Malaysian waters.

UANI says there have been 42 ship-to-ship transfers of Iranian oil conducted in the EOPL area since Feb 28, when the US and Israel attacked Iran, starting a war in the Middle East.

"Because of Malaysia's inaction, it is facilitating this business model by Iran and China and dark fleet actors," senior UANI adviser Charlie Brown said. AGENCIES

Pak PM Shehbaz to visit China next week

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif will undertake a three-day official visit to China from May 23, the government announced, amid growing strategic engagement between the two all-weather allies.

During the visit from May 23-26, the prime minister will also attend a business-to-business (B2B) forum on May 24, Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said while addressing the launch ceremony of the IBI Pakistan Digital Economy Centre here on Tuesday. AGENCIES

Iran frees rights lawyer Sotoudeh on bail: Report

DUBAI: - Iran has released on bail prominent human rights lawyer Nasrin Sotoudeh, who was arrested in early April in a crackdown during the conflict with the United States and Israel, Iranian news agencies and her daughter said on Wednesday.

Nournews, affiliated with Iran's top security body, said Sotoudeh was freed on bail, without referring to any charges she might still face. Mehraveh Khandan, Sotoudeh's daughter, confirmed her mother's release in a post on social media. AGENCIES

Trump administration freezes new Medicare enrolments for hospice, home health agencies

The move is related to efforts by VP JD Vance's anti-fraud task force

NEW YORK: The Trump administration said Wednesday it is expanding its sweeping fraud-busting initiative in federal health programs with a nationwide six-month freeze on any new Medicare enrolments by hospice and home health agencies.

The moratorium will temporarily stop all new providers in these categories from signing up for reimbursement from Medicare, the federal insurance program for older

"TODAY WE'RE SHUTTING THE DOOR ON FRAUD-PREVENTING NEW BAD ACTORS FROM ENTERING MEDICARE"

adults across the country, the Centres for Medicare and Medicaid Services said in a news release.

"We've seen systemic and deeply troubling fraud in the hospice and home health space, with bad actors exploiting some of our most vulnerable Medicare patients and stealing money from the American taxpayer," CMS Administrator Dr Mehmet Oz said in a statement.

"Today we're shutting the door on fraud-preventing new bad actors from entering Medicare while we aggressively identify, investi-

gate, and remove those already exploiting them."

The move is related to efforts by Vice President JD Vance's anti-fraud task force, set up by Republican President Donald Trump to crack down on potential misuse of public funds. It comes as people across the United States have raised concerns about rising health costs and barriers to access, sometimes from the federal government's own actions. AGENCIES

Board of Peace envoy Mladenov says ceasefire hinges on Hamas' disarmament

The truce envisioned Hamas handing over its weapons

JERUSALEM: Nickolay Mladenov, the top diplomat overseeing the U.S.-brokered ceasefire in Gaza, said Wednesday the truce hinged on Hamas' disarmament, a sticking point that has stalled progress on other fronts, including rebuilding the mostly destroyed enclave.

The high representative for U.S. President Donald Trump's International Board of Peace in Gaza, Mladenov, said months without progress implementing the deal benefited neither Israel nor Palestinians. He said the phased deal was paralyzed over Hamas not yet disarming, calling it "not negotiable."

International mediators have long said disarmament is core to the ceasefire, to which Hamas has agreed, but no significant progress has been made toward it. The Palestinian militant group has sought to link any demilitarization to Israeli troop pullbacks. Israel's military remains in control of more than half of Gaza.

"The only way that we believe that we can ensure that



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Israeli withdrawal takes place to the perimeter is if we have the full element of the plan unfolding in Gaza," Mladenov said at a rare press conference in Jerusalem.

Mladenov stated plainly that the plan envisioned in the ceasefire was off to a rocky start. He also said conditions remain dire and miserable for the more than 2 million people in Gaza.

He accused both sides of

violating the ceasefire but said it had mostly held and staved off the return of full-scale war.

Disarmament is among the most challenging elements of the ceasefire. Hamas, whose founding charter calls for armed resistance against Israel, has been reluctant to give up its arsenal, including rockets, anti-tank missiles, and explosives.

Mladenov did not answer questions about what could lie

LONDON: British King's speech, which annually sets out the parliamentary agenda of the UK government, was on Wednesday overshadowed by growing speculation of a ministerial coup against Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

King Charles III and Queen Camilla rode a horse-drawn carriage from Buckingham Palace to the Palace of Westminster in London as part of the customary pageantry associated with the State Opening of the British Parliament. How-



King Charles III with Queen Camilla

ever, Starmer's second outing as PM for the royal occasion since he led the Labour Party

to a resounding victory in the 2024 general election may just prove to be his last.

Allies close to UK Health Secretary Wes Streeting have indicated that he is preparing to resign from the Cabinet to formally launch his bid for the top job, after days of infighting following Labour's disastrous local election last week.

"An increasingly dangerous and volatile world threatens the United Kingdom, with the conflict in the Middle East only the most recent example. AGENCIES

World Briefs

EUROPEAN COMMISSION SEEKS TO BAN GAY 'CONVERSION THERAPY'

BRUSSELS: The European Commission said Wednesday it will ask all European Union nations to outlaw gay "conversion therapy" following a public campaign to ban the practice and just days before the annual Brussels Pride festival celebrating the LGBTQ+ community. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said Wednesday that "conversion practices" have "no place in our Union". Increasing protections for LGBTQ+ citizens has been long promised by the EU executive since she took office in 2019. The EU's Agency for Fundamental Rights said in 2024 that one in four LGBTQ+ citizens polled had been subjected to the scientifically discredited practice to attempt to change their sexual orientation or gender identity. Reports of the practice were highest in Greece, Cyprus, the Czech Republic, Estonia, and Slovakia.

GUNSHOTS FIRED IN PHILIPPINES SENATE

MANILA: A burst of gunfire rang out Wednesday night in the Philippine Senate, where authorities have tried to arrest a senator who is wanted by the International Criminal Court for a charge of crime against humanity, an Associated Press journalist and other witnesses said. It wasn't immediately clear what set off the gunfire or if there were injuries in the Senate chamber, where Sen. Ronald dela Rosa has stayed under the protection of allied senators as Philippine authorities tried to arrest him and possibly turn him over later to the ICC.

Takeaways

» Trump's 20-point plan says that all of Hamas' military, terror and offensive infrastructure in Gaza must be destroyed

» Israel's ensuing offensive has killed over 72,724 Palestinians, including at least 846 since a ceasefire took hold last October

ahead for Gaza in the absence of disarmament. He criticized Hamas for consolidating power in parts of Gaza under its control, saying it hoped "to squeeze better terms of a negotiation."

He also said that he could envision a role for Hamas in postwar Gaza if it disarms.

"We are not asking Hamas to disappear as a political movement," Mladenov told reporters. AGENCIES

EFFORTS TO BOOST CLEAN ENERGY PRODUCTION

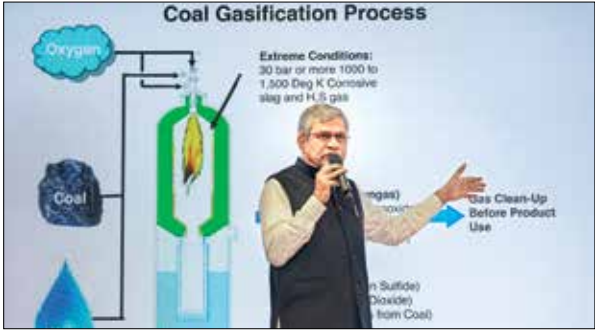
Govt approves Rs 37,500-cr incentive to promote coal gasification projects

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved a Rs 37,500-crore incentive scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of Rs 37,500 crore, an official statement said.

"An outlay of Rs 37,500 crore has been kept for this scheme, and there will be an investment of around Rs 3 lakh crore in this, and the projects



Union I&B minister Ashwini Vaishnaw during a press conference on Cabinet decisions, in New Delhi, Wednesday

will be put up for gasifying 75 million tonnes of coal," Union Information & Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said in a media briefing.

Vaishnaw said the country has 401 billion tonnes of known coal reserves, which is enough for the next 200 years.

"We all know about the current geopolitical situation. So

we have to take all the decisions to become Atma Nirbhar. In this context, a big decision on coal gasification was taken today," he said.

Coal gasification refers to the process of converting dry fuel into synthetic gas (syngas), which is used as an alternative fuel and helps reduce carbon emissions. This process sup-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » It aims at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol
- » 'The country has 401 billion tonnes of known coal reserves, which is enough for the next 200 years,' the minister said

energy security, and reducing dependence on imports of key products such as LNG, urea, ammonia and methanol.

"At present, more than 50 per cent of the LNG is currently imported, it will be reduced. The urea which we import will also start manufacturing in India. Ammonia is 100 per cent imported today. With this development, new avenues for ammonia production will open. Methanol is currently 80-90 per cent imported that will also be made in India," the minister said.

Under the scheme, the financial incentive at a maximum of 20 per cent of the cost of plant and machinery will be provided, the statement said, adding that the selection would be through a transparent and competitive bidding process, with an evaluation framework benchmarking project cost, coal input, and syngas output.

Cabinet approval clears path for Nagpur airport modernisation

Cabinet approves proposal to extend lease tenure of AAI land allotted to MIL

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet has approved a proposal to extend the lease tenure of Airports Authority of India (AAI) land allotted to MIHAN India Limited (MIL), paving the way for the handing over of management of Nagpur Airport to GMR Nagpur International Airport Limited (GNIAL).

Under the revised agreement framework, the airport's operation rights will now extend for 30 years following the Cabinet's approval. The decision is expected to provide fresh momentum to the Multimodal International Cargo Hub and Airport at Nagpur (MIHAN) project and support the expansion of operations at Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar International Airport.

The development is also expected to strengthen aviation and cargo infrastructure in central India.

MIL was established in 2009 as a joint venture between AAI and Maharashtra Airport Development Company (MADC) with a 49:51 shareholding pattern. Although airport assets were transferred to MIL the same year, leasing issues persisted due to unresolved boundary demarcation concerns.

Earlier, access to AAI land had been permitted only until August 6, 2039.

In 2016, MIL invited global

bids for operating the airport under a public-private partnership model. GMR Airports Limited emerged as the highest bidder by offering a revenue share proposal of 14.49 per cent. However, MIL cancelled the bidding process in 2020, triggering legal disputes. The Bombay High Court later ruled in favour of GMR Airports Ltd, and the verdict was subsequently upheld by the Supreme Court.

Following the Supreme Court's ruling in September 2024, MIL signed a concession agreement with GNIAL in October 2024. The agreement formalised the operational framework after the conclusion of legal proceedings.

With the Cabinet's latest approval, the extended lease period will now align with GNIAL's 30-year concession term beyond 2039, facilitating the transfer process and enabling long-term redevelopment of the airport site.

The synchronisation of lease and concession timelines is expected to support a smoother operational transition and faster project implementation.

The airport expansion project will be executed in phases and is designed to handle 30 million passengers annually. The plan also includes major cargo infrastructure upgrades aimed at improving connectivity across Vidarbha and central India.

Tamil Nadu, UP and Mizoram outperform other states in logistics performance ranking

NEW DELHI: Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Mizoram and Delhi have been categorised as 'exemplars' in the logistics performance ranking for 2025, according to a report released by the Commerce and Industry Ministry on Wednesday.

The logistics index chart, released as part of LEADS (Logistics ease across different states) 2025 report, is an indicator of the efficiency of logistical services necessary for promoting exports and economic growth.

'Exemplars' represent the top-performing states and Union Territories (UTs) that demonstrate sustained excellence across policy, infrastructure, service delivery and regulatory dimensions in the logistics sector, as per the report. LEADS is the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade's (DPIIT) flagship national assessment of logistics performance across

The report was released by Commerce minister Piyush Goyal in the national capital

states and Union Territories and serves as an important benchmarking and reform tool for improving logistics efficiency across the country.

The report was released by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal in the national capital. As per the report, 11 states and UTs - Gujarat, Kerala, Maharashtra, Haryana, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Tripura, Meghalaya, Jammu and Kashmir, and Puducherry - have been categorised as "high performers".

High Performers comprise states and UTs that demonstrate strong and consistent outcomes across the majority of perfor-

mance indicators.

Similarly, 18 states and UTs have been categorised as 'accelerators'. The category includes Andhra Pradesh, Odisha, Goa, Karnataka, Punjab, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh, Manipur, Assam, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Chandigarh, Ladakh, and Lakshadweep. Accelerators comprise states and Union Territories that have demonstrated notable improvement momentum and a clear reform orientation in recent years.

The 'growth seekers' category includes West Bengal, Rajasthan, Sikkim and Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

Growth Seekers represent states and UTs that are at a foundational stage of logistics system development and institutional strengthening.

The 2025 report moves beyond the traditional 'Achiev-

'RBI likely to pay record dividend to govt this year'

Centre expects Rs 3.16L crore in dividends & surpluses

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is expected to pay the highest-ever dividend to the government, providing the Centre with a fiscal cushion to address challenges arising from the ongoing Middle East crisis, sources said.

Last year the RBI made a record dividend payout of Rs 2.69 lakh crore to the central government for 2024-25, 27 per cent higher than Rs 2.11 lakh crore transferred in the previous year.

RBI is likely to decide about dividend quantum in its board meeting expected to be held during this month, sources said. The transferable surplus for any financial year is arrived at on the basis of the revised Economic Capital Framework (ECF) as approved by the Central Board of the RBI.

The revised framework stipulates that the risk provi-



sioning under the Contingent Risk Buffer (CRB) be maintained within a range of 7.50 to 4.50 per cent of the RBI's balance sheet.

As per the Budget documents, the Centre expects Rs 3.16 lakh crore in dividends and surpluses from the Reserve Bank of India, nationalised banks, and financial institutions in 2026-27, up about 3.75 per cent over the current fiscal.

The government had made conservative estimates, sources said, dividend payouts would exceed the Budget Estimate for FY27 as public sector banks (PSBs) have also posted a record profit in FY26.

Improved asset quality,

healthy credit expansion and higher income contributed to improved profitability of PSBs during FY 2025-26. Aggregate operating profit reached Rs 3.21 lakh crore, while aggregate net profit increased by 11.1 per cent to a historic high of Rs 1.98 lakh crore, marking the fourth consecutive year of aggregate profitability for PSBs.

Budget documents further showed that dividends from public sector enterprises and other investments are estimated at Rs 75,000 crore, up from Rs 71,000 crore in the current fiscal.

Dividend and Reserve Bank's surplus transfers fall under the non-tax revenue category. In all, the Centre expects Rs 6.66 lakh crore as non-tax revenue next fiscal, lower than 6.67 lakh crore in 2025-26.

The revenue from taxes has been pegged at Rs 28.66 lakh crore, up 7.18 per cent from Rs 26.74 lakh crore in 2025-26.

AI could add over \$500 bn to India's economy by '30

Most business leaders believe AI investments will directly influence India's GDP growth

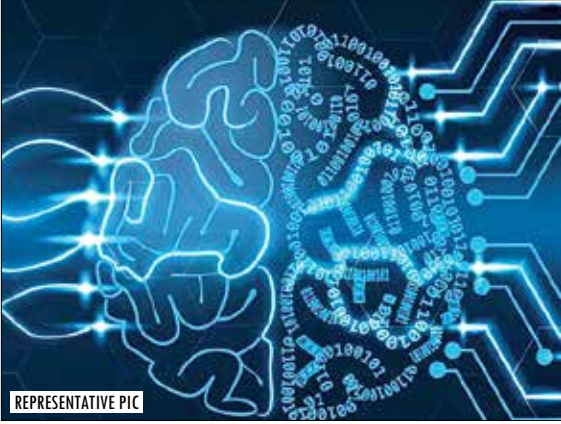
MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Artificial Intelligence (AI) has the potential to contribute over USD 500 billion (about Rs 47.81 lakh crore) to India's economy by 2030, according to a new joint study by IBM and IndiaAI, a MeitY initiative.

The report, titled "From Promise to Power: How AI Is Redefining India's Economic Future", surveyed 1,500 Indian executives from a range of industries and organisations, covering various leadership levels, including CXOs. The study was supplemented by a pulse survey of 405 Indian executives.

The report revealed that 80 per cent of Indian business leaders surveyed believe AI investments will directly influence the nation's GDP growth.

"AI could contribute more than USD 500 billion to India's economy by 2030, positioning the country among the world's most dynamic AI-driven economies. Few countries are stepping into the AI era with India's mix of scale, digital muscle, and ambition," the report said. Around 73 per cent of Indian



executives believe the country will be a leading AI nation by 2030—a bet built on a vast market, a pioneering digital public infrastructure, and the world's largest IT services workforce, according to the report.

However, the research also highlighted a critical "inflection gap", with 72 per cent of surveyed organisations acknowledging they currently lag behind their global peers in AI adoption.

Currently, only 15 per cent of organisations are scaling AI through cross-functional investments, while the remaining 85 per cent are stuck in the

pilot stage.

Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (MeitY) Secretary S Krishnan said India is no longer just participating in the global AI conversation but helping shape it.

"Our vision is clear. AI must evolve as an extension of our people's aspirations, driving inclusive growth and national progress. Guided by our vision of Viksit Bharat, we are advancing a human-centric approach to AI rooted in trust, ethics, and national sovereignty," he said.

The study identified significant barriers to AI readiness.

KEY POINTS

- » The report, titled 'From Promise to Power: How AI Is Redefining India's Economic Future', surveyed 1,500 Indian executives from a range of industries and organisations, covering various leadership levels, including CXOs
- » The study was supplemented by a pulse survey of 405 Indian executives



Services shipments too surged to an all-time high of USD 421.32 billion in 2025-26, compared to USD 387.55 billion in 2024-25, recording a growth of 8.71 per cent.

"This year, let's aspire for a USD 1 trillion exports target. It's possible," he said at an event here.

The minister said that taking from USD 863 billion to USD 1 trillion needs USD 137 billion, which is a 16-17 per cent growth.

The minister added that India is opening doors and is providing preferential market access for Indian goods and ser-

“The world is looking to work & trade with India as the country provides huge market and a talented workforce”

finalised.

"Four of which (FTAs) are already operational and another 5 will be operational in the next 12 months," Goyal said. Trade pacts with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, and the European Free Trade Association (EFTA) bloc have been

operationalised so far.

The minister said that India is also negotiating FTAs with a number of other countries.

"...today, I met two ministers from two different countries, Chile and Maldives, both of which agreements are stated to be completed before the end of this year," he said, adding that India is also in active dialogue with Canada, Israel, the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), and Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU).

"We are also planning to start talking to Mexico. We will soon start a conversation with the Southern Afri-

can Customs Union (SACU). We are trying to expand the Mercosur (Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay) preferential trade agreement (PTA) to a much more robust trading arrangement," he added. Goyal said that the world is looking to work and trade with India as the country provides huge market and a talented workforce.

On FTA utilisation, he said the commerce ministry on Wednesday held a virtual meeting with over 1,100 participants, including industry associations, to apprise them of the benefits of these agreements.

Withdrawal of retirement funds soon to be 'automated': EPFO

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Retirement fund body EPFO will soon automate the process for settling final provident fund withdrawal claims, fast-tracking the money transfer to the applicant's bank accounts, a top official said on Wednesday.

The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has more than seven crore members.

At present, partial or advance withdrawal claims of up to Rs 5 lakh are settled through auto mode, and the deadline for the auto-settlement mode is three days from filing the claim.

Speaking at the ASSOCHAM's National Seminar on New Labour Codes, Central Provident Fund Commissioner, EPFO, Ramesh Krishnamurthi, said, "We are also going to initiate, as far as feasible, auto-settlement for now...which was (available) only for advances. Now we are going in for auto-settlement of final withdrawals."

He further added that the EPFO is going in for auto-settlement and auto-transfer of provident fund accounts in case a member shifts

INSIGHT

- » The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) has more than seven crore members
- » At present, partial or advance withdrawal claims of up to Rs 5L are settled through auto mode, and the deadline for the auto-settlement mode is 3 days from filing the claim

that pertain specifically to the EPFO would be published shortly. Under the new legal framework, the three schemes - EPF Scheme 1952, Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance Scheme 1976 and Employees Pension Scheme 1995 - will also be renotified.

"We have not gone in for major changes. We have tried to integrate all the learnings from the past. We have included all the recent central board of trustees approved decisions, which include simplification of the withdrawals and other such reforms, including a major overhaul of the provisions relating to the exempt trust. Those have been included in the new schemes," he added. On this occasion, Union Labour Secretary Vandana Gurnani said that labour is in the concurrent list of the Constitution, and states will frame their own rules.

The philosophy of the government has been to balance the compliance reduction, ease of doing business, ease of expanding business, and ensuring that the workers are not shortchanged, she said.

MAY ADD TO MSME WOES

Duty hike won't cut gold imports: Industry

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPC) on Wednesday said raising gold import duty does not curb imports but inflates prices, and urged the government to hold talks with industry stakeholders for sustainable solutions.

"Hiking import duties rarely curbs gold imports, it merely inflates prices. Despite gold prices doubling recently, imports have not declined proportionally," the council said in a statement.

GJEPC said higher duties fuel smuggling and raise export costs, while exporters now face bank guarantees of Rs 28-30 lakh per kg of duty-free gold sourced from Nominated Agencies, severely blocking working capital.

The most severe impact would be on MSME manufacturers, who account for 80 per



HIGHLIGHTS

» GJEPC said higher duties fuel smuggling and raise export costs, while exporters now face bank guarantees of Rs 28-30 lakh per kg of duty-free gold sourced from Nominated Agencies, severely blocking working capital

» The most severe impact would be on MSME manufacturers, who account for 80 per cent of GJEPC's membership and are facing a 'critical liquidity crunch', it said

arately submitting a detailed paper on revitalising the Gold Monetisation Scheme to the government. "GJEPC urges the government to engage in dialogue for sustainable solutions that align fiscal goals with export growth," it said.

Meanwhile, jewellers and industry leaders said the hike in import duty on gold and silver could impact jewellery volumes in the short term, though demand is expected to remain resilient due to the yellow metal's enduring cultural and investment appeal in India.

Retailers said imposing quantitative restrictions on gold and silver imports, rather than raising import duties, would be a more effective way to curb the country's current account deficit (CAD).

They said that increasing import duties often drives up prices in the domestic market, hurts small and medium-sized enterprises.

Imports from Dubai may rise

Think tank GTRI said that the duty hike may lead to an increase in imports from Dubai through the free trade agreement route.

It said that the duty hike also sharply changes the economics of precious metal imports routed through the United Arab Emirates under the India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

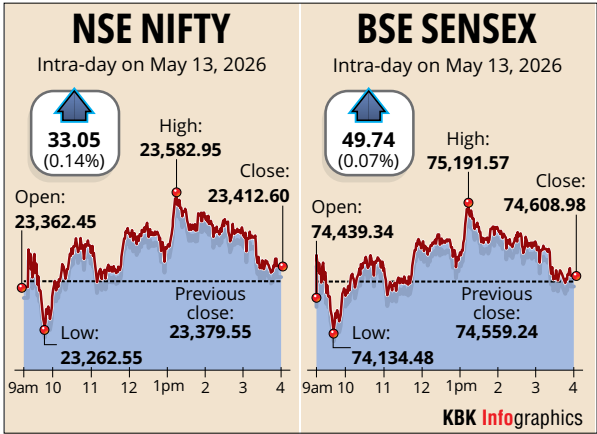
India had allowed imports of gold from Dubai at tariffs one percentage point below the normal Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) rate through a Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) system.

The quota began at 120 tonnes annually in 2022 and is set to rise to 200 tonnes by 2027, nearly one-fourth of India's yearly gold imports.

"With the new MFN tariff structure taking effective duties to 15 per cent, gold imported under the UAE quota would enter at 14 per cent.

Sensex, Nifty snap 4-day losing streak

Rupee hits a fresh record low



MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended marginally higher on Wednesday, snapping their four-session losing streak, following bargain hunting in metal, energy, and consumption stocks amid a largely supportive trend overseas.

However, the rupee hitting a fresh record low and unrelenting foreign fund outflows amid elevated crude oil prices and persistent geopolitical uncertainties capped the gains, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex rose 49.74 points, or 0.07 per cent, to settle at 74,608.98. During the day, the index touched a high of 75,191.57 and a low of 74,134.48, gyrating 1,057.09 points.

The 50-share NSE edged higher by 33.05 points or 0.14 per cent to end at 23,412.60.

From the Sensex constituents, Asian Paints, Tata Steel, Adani Ports, Bharat Electronics, Bharti Airtel and Larsen & Toubro were among the winners. Mahindra & Mahindra, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Sun Pharma and Tech Mahindra were among the biggest laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.90 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index edged higher by 0.41 per cent.

"Markets witnessed a volatile yet relatively stable session on Wednesday following the sharp sell-off seen over the

previous four trading sessions. Sectoral participation remained mixed, with metals, energy, and FMCG stocks showing relative resilience, while IT and auto counters continued to witness pressure," Ajit Mishra - SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, fell 0.5 per cent to USD 107.27 per barrel.

FII offloaded equities worth Rs 1,959.39 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

Meanwhile, the rupee on Wednesday slipped to an all-time low of 95.80 against the US dollar, and settled at 95.66 near its record closing low level, as the cumulative strain of elevated crude prices and West Asia geopolitical concerns offset hopes of lower demand for the US dollar due to import curbs.

Forex traders said possible RBI intervention and duty-led compression of gold imports helped moderate further weakness for the USD/INR pair, but the rupee was pressured by the trajectory of crude and the West Asia situation.

The rupee has become the worst-performing currency in Asia for the year, registering a loss of over 6 per cent so far this year, as elevated crude oil prices, a strong dollar and concerns regarding the West Asia crisis weighed on investor sentiments, traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.52, registering a gain of 16 paise from its previous all-time closing low.

Govt hikes paddy MSP to Rs 2,441/qlt

Sunflower seed sees steepest rise

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday announced a hike in the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for paddy by Rs 72 to Rs 2,441 per quintal for the 2026-27 kharif marketing season, while steeper increases for pulses, oilseeds and cotton aimed at reducing import dependency and encouraging crop diversification.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved MSPs for 14 kharif crops ahead of sowing, which typically begins in June with the onset of the southwest monsoon.

For paddy, the MSP for common and A-grade varieties stands at Rs 2,441 and Rs 2,461 per quintal, respectively for 2026-27 kharif marketing season (September-October).

The MSP for cotton (medium staple) has been raised by Rs 557 to Rs 8,267 per quintal, while the long staple variety will fetch Rs 8,667 per quintal – the second-highest absolute increase among all crops.

The highest absolute increase, however, has been recommended for sunflower seed at Rs 622 per quintal, taking its MSP to Rs 8,343 per quintal. Nigarseed (up Rs 515 to Rs 10,052/qlt) and sesamum (up Rs 500 to Rs 10,346/qlt) also received significant increases.

Among other oilseeds,

soyabean (yellow) was raised by Rs 380 to Rs 5,708 per quintal and groundnut by Rs 254 to Rs 7,517 per quintal.

In pulses, tur (arhar) MSP was raised by Rs 450 to Rs 8,450 per quintal, urad by Rs 400 to Rs 8,200 per quintal, while moong saw a marginal increase of Rs 12 to Rs 8,780 per quintal.

For other cereals, jowar (hybrid) MSP has been fixed at Rs 4,023 per quintal (up Rs 324), with the Maldandi variety at Rs 4,073 per quintal. Bajra has been raised by Rs 125 to Rs 2,900 per quintal, ragi by Rs 319 to Rs 5,205 per quintal, and maize by Rs 10 to Rs 2,410 per quintal.

Briefing reporters, Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the MSPs have been fixed to ensure remunerative prices for farmers and are at least 50 per cent above the cost of production across all 14 crops. The margins are estimated to be highest for moong (61 per cent), followed by bajra and maize (56 per cent each) and tur/arhar (54 per cent).

For the remaining crops, the margin is pegged at 50 per cent. The government estimates the total payout to farmers at Rs 2.60 lakh crore, with annual procurement projected at 824.41 lakh tonne.

Indian Vegetable Oil Producers' Association (IVPA) president Sudhakar Desai welcomed the MSP hike for oilseeds but reiterated the need for stable and dynamic import duty framework.

AEPC seeks removal of import duty on cotton

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC) on Wednesday urged the government to remove the 11 per cent import duty on cotton as rising input costs are impacting the textiles industry.

AEPC chairman A Sakthivel met Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, and Textiles Minister Giriraj Singh, along with a delegation from the apparel industry and submitted representations seeking the duty cut.

They have sought "reduction of import duty on cotton from the existing 11 per cent to 0 per cent", the council said in a statement.

The delegation highlighted challenges being faced by the apparel and textile industry due to high cotton prices and rising input costs, it said.

India and Chile review progress of negotiations for proposed FTA

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India and Chile, a South American nation, on Wednesday reviewed the progress of negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement and discussed modalities for its early conclusion, an official statement said.

Chilean Foreign Affairs Minister Francisco Perez Mackenna held meetings with Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal here. The Chilean minister is leading a delegation here.

"Apart from discussing the modalities for early conclusion of Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), the interactions also covered a broad range of issues relating to trade facilitation, market access, investment promotion and strengthening institutional economic engage-

KEY POINTS

» Chilean Foreign Affairs Minister Francisco Perez Mackenna held meetings with Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal in New Delhi

» In 2006, India and Chile implemented a preferential trade agreement and are now negotiating to widen its scope for a CEPA

ment between the two countries," the Commerce ministry said. Both sides also deliberated upon ways to enhance collaboration in sectors such as critical minerals, renewable energy, agri-business, infrastructure, pharmaceuticals,

OIL reports sharp rise in profit, decade-high daily crude production

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Oil India Limited (OIL) on Wednesday reported strong operational and financial performance for the fourth quarter of FY26, driven by higher crude oil production, improved crude price realisation and robust upstream operations. The Maharatna Central Public Sector Enterprise announced its results following a meeting of its Board of Directors held on Tuesday.

The company posted a profit after tax (PAT) of Rs 2,424 crore in Q1 FY26, marking a sharp 62 per cent

increase from Rs 1,497 crore recorded in the corresponding quarter of FY25, OIL said in a statement.

For the full financial year ended March 31, the company's consolidated PAT stood at Rs 7,551 crore, compared with Rs 7,040 crore in the previous fiscal, reflecting steady annual growth despite uncertainty in the global energy market.

On a standalone basis, OIL reported a PAT of Rs 1,790 crore in Q4 FY26, higher than Rs 1,591 crore in the year-ago quarter.

The increase in profitability was attributed mainly to a 6 per cent rise in crude oil



In Q1 FY26, the company posted a profit after tax of Rs 2,424 crore

production and a 5 per cent

increase in crude oil price realisation.

Average crude oil realisation rose from USD 74.46 per barrel in Q4 FY25 to USD 77.89 per barrel in Q4 FY26.

The Board of Directors also recommended a final dividend of Rs 1 per equity share of face value Rs 10 each.

This was in addition to the first and second interim dividends of Rs 3.50 and Rs 7 per equity share, respectively, paid during the financial year.

Highlighting operational achievements, the company said it produced 0.891 million metric tonnes (MMT) of crude oil from its mature and declin-

ing fields in Q4 FY26, compared with 0.844 MMT in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal.

In a major milestone, OIL achieved its highest daily crude oil production in the last decade at 10,566 metric tonnes.

The company also completed a record 307 workovers during the year, the highest in its history.

Officials said the aggressive drilling programme helped OIL maintain a Reserve Replacement Ratio of above one, indicating that it replenished reserves at a rate higher than production.

Meanwhile, Numaligarh Refinery Limited (NRL), a key subsidiary of OIL, also posted strong financial results in FY26.

NRL's PAT surged 90 per cent to Rs 3,057 crore from Rs 1,608 crore in FY25, while the refinery reported a Gross Refining Margin (GRM) of USD 13.43 per barrel during the year.

These strong performances by both OIL and NRL are timely, considering that India still remains committed to increasing its own production capacity while reducing its dependency on external supplies of hydrocarbons.

'A WINDFALL FOR CHINA'

Price shocks from Iran war power solar sales in Asia

MANILA: Soaring costs for fuel due to the Iran war are leading panicked consumers in hard-hit Asia toward rooftop solar power, a likely windfall for China as the world's largest producer of solar technology.

In the Philippines, which is in a national energy emergency, a survey of 20 local solar companies found a 70 per cent increase in weekly installations and a six-fold jump in customer inquiries since the conflict began. "This crisis is a driving force for solar," said Brenda Valerio of the nonprofit New Energy Nexus, which ran the survey. "People want solar and people want solar now."

China is poised to profit from demand caused by the war. Chinese clean technology equipment exports hit a record high in March, according to energy think tank Ember, and worldwide interest in solar is increasing.

"China really is, by far, leading this race," said Li Shuo, director of the Asia Society Policy Institute's China Climate Hub, who called the renewable industry "a one-man show."

Iran war drives solar sales

The Philippines, which relies heavily on Middle East-



CLOSER LOOK

» In the Philippines, a survey found a 70% increase in weekly installations and a six-fold jump in customer inquiries

» China is poised to profit from demand caused by the war

» Chinese clean technology equipment exports hit a record high in March

ern crude oil and liquefied natural gas, is among the most impacted Southeast Asian nations by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Local airlines are weighing fuel rationing. Public transport workers are receiving cash handouts. Gas and diesel prices also have shot up. To conserve energy, government offices have shifted to a four-day work week and been told to keep air conditioning no lower than 24 degrees Celsius (75 degrees Fahrenheit).

Oil and gas spikes during the first 60 days of the Iran war cost Filipino consumers, businesses and public institutions more than USD 600 million, the climate nonprofit 350.org estimates.

"When we got our energy bill after the Iran war broke out, we were very shocked. It was wow. It was a significant increase," said Jaime Quemado, who recently bought a rooftop solar system in Manila.

There also have been growing concerns about potential power outages, Quemado said, which led him to look for an alternative energy source like "solar, which is very abundant here in the Philippines".

Customer interest in rooftop solar jumped from around 115 inquiries in February, before the start of the Iran war on February 28, to more than 450 by mid-April, according to the New Energy Nexus survey.

Solar groups must "ride this wave and take advantage of this

momentum", Valerio said.

On two blisteringly hot days in Manila, EcoSolutions installers sweated through the set up of an 18-kilowatt rooftop solar system, which included 28 panels from major Chinese manufacturer LONGi and four batteries from Suzhou-based battery group Dyneus.

The war has "helped the solar industry really get its footing," EcoSolutions president Richmond Reyes said.

Joel Remegio of the Association of Solar Installers of the Philippines said the energy crisis is a "game changer" for the nation's nascent solar industry.

Clean technology, like rooftop solar, is quickly scalable because it is "accessible to all of us," according to Marissa

Cerezo of the Department of Energy's Renewable Energy Management Bureau.

This "gives us the power to choose them," she said.

Solar interest rises globally

Solar is being embraced across Southeast Asia. Indonesia set an ambitious target to install 100 gigawatts of rooftop solar by 2034, a leap from its current 1.3 gigawatts. Vietnam wants to install rooftop solar on at least 10 per cent of public offices and homes nationwide by 2030.

Thailand is considering new policies to give rooftop solar users a bigger bang for their buck by increasing the amount of surplus energy the national grid can buy. The energy crisis is incentivizing these decisions, according to Yu Sun Chin of the research group Zero Carbon Analytics.

"It totally makes sense for policymakers to take another look at rooftop solar and see ways that they can save costs," she said.

Online marketplaces and utility companies in the US and across Europe also have recorded jumps in solar sales and inquiries since the Iran war began.

AGENCIES

Air India suspends services on 6 int'l routes

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Air India on Wednesday announced reduction of international flights and temporary suspension of services on six routes, including Delhi-Chicago, amid airspace curbs and high jet fuel prices.

The loss-making airline, which has already reduced flights on certain routes, said the latest announced rationalisation of services will be in place during the June-August period. A combination of factors, including continued airspace restrictions over certain regions and record high jet fuel prices for international operations, are significantly impacting the commercial viability of certain planned services, Air India said in a statement.

The loss-making airline will be temporarily suspending services on Delhi-Chicago, Mumbai-New York, Delhi-Shanghai, Chennai-Singapore, Mumbai-Dhaka, and Delhi-Male routes till August.

The airline will continue to operate more than 1,200 international flights every month, it said.

MPOST

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Amul and Mother Dairy - India's largest dairy product retailers - on Wednesday hiked milk prices by Rs 2 per litre, intensifying inflationary pressures already fuelled by the war and squeezing household budgets.

The increase, the second by the two dairy cooperatives in 13 months, is expected to prompt similar hikes by regional dairy companies.

Gujarat Cooperative Milk Marketing Federation (GCMMF), which markets milk and milk products under the Amul brand, in a statement, said it has "increased the prices of fresh pouch milk by Rs 2 per litre in major milk-selling variants/packs across India effective from May 14".

Separately, Mother Dairy said it has revised the consumer prices of its liquid milk variants by Rs 2 per litre, effective Thursday.

The last price increase by GCMMF was on May 1, 2025, while Mother Dairy had raised rates in April 2025.

The price increase by India's two largest organised milk retailers will add to food inflation, which has risen in recent weeks due to the conflict in West Asia.

GCMMF said the increase in prices translates to about 2.5-3.5 per cent per litre, which is lower than the average food inflation.

"The price hike is being done due to an increase in the overall cost of operation and production of milk. There is a substantial increase in the cost of cattle feed, milk packaging film and fuel during the year," GCMMF said.

The cooperative said its member unions have also increased farmers' procurement price by Rs 30 per kg of fat, which is a 3.7 per cent increase over May 2025.

On the price hike, Mother Dairy said, "The revision has been necessitated in view of the sustained increase in farmer procurement prices, of around 6 per cent over the past one year, despite continued efforts to limit the impact on consumers".



'I dove into 'Kartavya' because I love the script,' he says

'Kartavya' is one of the best roles that have come my way'

Saif Ali Khan described the crime-drama as a gripping, well-crafted story with compelling characters

Saif Ali Khan said he was instinctively drawn to the world of 'Kartavya', which he described as a gripping, well-crafted story with compelling characters.

Directed by Pulkit of 'Bhaskhak' fame, the crime-drama follows a police officer (Khan), as he navigates rising threats while grappling with the weight of duty and the safety of his family. As the lines between right and

wrong begin to blur, the film unfolds as a layered exploration of power, guilt and the consequences of silence.

"I dove into 'Kartavya' because I love the script. I think it is a great drama and a really interesting, almost international kind of piecing together of things. I had not read a script like this, and people who read it and discussed it at the time said that this is one of the best roles that have come my way," Khan told PTI in an interview.

The actor said 'Kartavya' has an international feel, in which his character, a policeman, Pawan, is pushed to take extreme decisions. "The world is beautifully crafted, the kind of character he is, where he is from, how he speaks, the home, the things that are at risk,



how it slowly establishes what is happening. He might be a bit fed up with the way life is going and then it slowly builds. You add pressure in these scenes, and he starts reacting," the 55-year-old

actor said.

Khan also addressed comparisons between his role in 'Kartavya' and his widely acclaimed performance as Langda Tyagi in the 2006 movie, 'Omkaar'. "Omkaar" is Hindi heartland. I think the voice might sound a little similar; the accent might be similar."

When asked about choosing roles in an industry often dominated by larger-than-life spectacles, Khan said his approach has always been guided by instinct rather than scale.

"I've tried to play whatever is the best of what I'm offered and how I'm feeling. My manager at the time had said, 'We're kind of platform agnostic, we will do anything within reason, if we like it,'" he said. PTI

VIMAL KHANNA

Taking a survival thriller character from books to screens

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player' unveiled the gripping trailer of its upcoming survival thriller 'Vimal Khanna'. Adapted from the iconic universe 'The Vimal Series', by Surender Mohan Pathak, brings one of Hindi literature's most enduring characters to the screen. The show is headlined by Sunny Hinduja in the titular role, alongside Isha Talwar and Tara Alisha Berry. Set to premiere on May 15, the series plunges into a tense, unpredictable world where identity is fragile, trust is dangerous and every move

comes at a cost.

The trailer sets the tone for a relentless survival thriller, as Vimal Khanna finds himself constantly on the run, pulled deeper into a dangerous spiral of betrayal, deception and survival, where every escape only pushes him further in. As secrets begin to unfold and hidden motives come to light, one question begins to linger: Vimal Khanna bachega ya marega? Will he find a way out or get pulled further into the spiral?

Wrongfully accused and stripped of his identity, Vimal's fight for innocence soon turns into a battle against a system determined to destroy him.



As control slips, every move feels anticipated and every escape comes at a cost, pulling him deeper into a complex web. With its raw fiction

edge and emotional intensity, Vimal Khanna builds a gritty, urban world driven by paranoia, shifting loyalty and the instinct to survive.

Speaking about the show and his character, Sunny Hinduja said, "Working on 'Vimal Khanna' with 'Amazon MX Player' has been an immersive experience. Vimal isn't a conventional hero; he's an ordinary man pushed into extraordinary circumstances, where survival becomes instinct. What drew me to the character is his internal conflict, the constant struggle between holding on to his identity and adapting to a system that's working against him. There's a saying, 'Ye Alag Mitti Ka Bana Hai', which is apt for Vimal and his journey is what makes him both vulnerable and powerful."

Politics and art not in conflict: Park Chan-wook

The Cannes jury head distinguished political art and propaganda at the press conference

South Korean auteur Park Chan-wook, who heads the jury for the 2026 edition of the Cannes Film Festival, said he doesn't believe that politics and art are in conflict.

Speaking early in a 50-minute opening press conference of the 78th Cannes Film Festival here on Tuesday, the celebrated director of 'Oldboy', 'The Handmaiden' and 'Decision to Leave', also distinguished political art and propaganda.

"I don't think politics and art should be divided. It's a strange concept to think they conflict with each other. Just because a work of art has a political statement, it shouldn't be considered an enemy of art. At the same time, just because a film is not making a political statement, that film should not be ignored," Park said.

He added, "Even if we are to make a brilliant political statement, if it is not expressed artfully enough, it would just be propaganda."

At the film gala, Park said he is prepared to watch films with the 'pure eyes of an audience member'.

"...without any prejudice or stereotype, just excitement to watch films that will surprise me," he added.



'It's a strange concept to think they conflict with each other,' he says

The remarks come months after a major controversy at the 76th Berlin International Film Festival, where jury president Wim Wenders sparked a debate by telling reporters that filmmakers 'have to stay out of politics because if we make movies that are dedicatedly political, we enter the field of politics'. His comments triggered both online and offline backlash as more than 80 industry figures, among them actors Javier Bardem and Tilda Swinton, signed an open letter criticising the Berlinale for what they called its 'silence' over the war in Gaza.

The 2026 Cannes Film Festival will conclude on May 23. PTI

Conan O'Brien set to return as Oscars host next year

Comedian Conan O'Brien will return to host the Oscars for the third consecutive year in 2027, Academy CEO Bill Kramer and Academy President Lynette Howell Taylor announced.

O'Brien is set to reunite with producers Raj Kapoor and Katy Mullan, who return as the show's executive producers for the fourth consecutive year. In contrast, Jeff Ross and Mike Sweeney will return as producers for a third time. Sweeney will also serve as a writer.

"We are thrilled to be working again with Conan, Raj, Katy, Jeff and Mike for the 99th Oscars. They are an incredible team and have produced such captivating, entertaining and heartfelt shows over the last two years. We are so grateful for their ongoing partnership as we honour our global film community and we look forward to Conan superbly leading the celebration with his brilliance and humour," said Kramer and Howell Taylor.

Craig Erwich, President of 'Disney Television Group', praised O'Brien for creating remarkable energy around the Oscars. "His singular comedic voice makes Hollywood's biggest night one of the most entertaining celebrations of the year. We're proud to welcome him back and look forward to what he and the producing team deliver next," Erwich said.

Kapoor and Mullan said getting to work with O'Brien for a third year at the Oscars is really special. "He brings that signature humour everyone loves, along with a real warmth and generosity that carries through the entire show. He's a true creative partner, someone we trust completely and someone who makes the whole process genuinely fun, both behind the scenes and on stage. We're incredibly grateful to keep building this together and can't wait to share what's next," said Kapoor and Mullan.



The 99th Oscars will be held on March 14, 2027

O'Brien is best known for hosting the late-night talk shows 'Late Night with Conan O'Brien', 'The Tonight Show with Conan O'Brien' and 'Conan'. Before his more than two-decade hosting career, he served as a writer for 'Saturday Night Live' and 'The Simpsons'. Currently, he hosts the 'Conan O'Brien Needs a Friend' podcast and the HBO travel show 'Conan O'Brien Must Go'. He has won six Primetime Emmys and earned 33 nominations, including a nomination for his work on the Oscars.

The 99th Oscars will be held on March 14, 2027, at the Dolby Theatre at Ovation Hollywood and will be televised live on ABC, streamed live on 'Hulu' and aired in more than 200 territories worldwide. PTI

SHARE TO SHINE

A LIGHT FOR BOTH THE GIVER AND THE RECEIVER

The meaning of sharing has always been greater than the act itself

AUTHOR



DR. ACHYUTA SAMANTA

The meaning of sharing has always been greater than the act itself. One may share food, one may share time. One may share knowledge, one may share love or one may share even a small word of hope. But when it's done with a pure heart and without any expectation, it becomes a light for both the giver and the receiver.

'Share to Shine', the theme of the 13th anniversary of 'Art of Giving', is a very simple but deeply spiritual thought. It tells us that by sharing what we have, we don't become less. Rather, we become brighter in our own lives because the joy of another person becomes a part of our own happiness.

In our ancient Indian wisdom, giving has never been seen only as charity. It is seen as a duty, as a discipline and as a path to inner purification.

The 'Taittiriya Upanishad' says, 'अद्वया देयम्। अश्रद्धयाऽदेयम्। श्रिया देयम्। मिया देयम्। सविदा देयम्' (Shraddhaya deyam, ashraaddhaya adeyam, shriya deyam, hriya deyam, bhiya deyam, samvida deyam), which means give with faith; do not give without faith. Give with grace, give with humility, give with responsibility and give with understanding. This is the true spirit of 'Share to Shine'. Sharing shouldn't come from pride. It should come from respect for the other person and from a feeling that the same divinity lives in all.

In the 'Bhagavad Gita' also, Lord Krishna explains to Arjuna that the best form of giving is that which is given at the right place, at the right time, to a worthy person and without any expectation of return. This is 'Sattvik Daan'. This thought is very close to the philosophy of 'Art of Giving', propounded by Shree Achyuta Samanta, who has shown through his life that giving isn't a matter of wealth, but a matter of the heart.

'Share to Shine' can be practised by every person in day-to-day life. A teacher can



'Share to Shine', the theme of the 13th anniversary of 'Art of Giving', is a very simple but deeply spiritual thought

can share food with a hungry person. A child can share a smile with an elderly person. Each act may look small, but its effect can be very large.

The sun shines because it gives light. The river remains pure because it flows and gives water. The tree stands silently and gives fruits, shade and oxygen without asking anything in return. Nature itself teaches us that sharing is the law of life. When we stop sharing, we become closed within ourselves. When we start sharing, we become connected with the universe.

परोपकाराय फलन्ति वृक्षाः, परोपकाराय वहन्ति नद्यः। परोपकाराय दुहन्ति गावः, परोपकारार्थमिदं शरीरम्।।

(Paropakaraya phalanti vrikshah, paropakaraya vahanti nadyah, paropakaraya duhanti gavah, paropakaratham idam shariram), which means, trees bear fruits for others; rivers flow for others; cows give milk for others and this human body is meant for the service of others. Therefore, 'Share to Shine' isn't only a theme for one celebration. It's a call to make sharing a habit, a culture and a way of living.

In this age of technology and fast life, people may have more facilities but less time for each other. Many are connected through devices, but lonely in heart. In such a time, sharing time, listening to someone, guiding a young mind, supporting a needy family, teaching a skill, donating books, feeding someone or simply speaking with kindness can become a great act of giving.

The 13th anniversary of 'Art of Giving' with the theme 'Share to Shine' reminds us that goodness should not remain locked inside us. Whatever good we have must travel to others. When knowledge is shared, it becomes wisdom. When food is shared, it becomes Prasad. When love is shared, it becomes devotion. When happiness is shared, it becomes peace.

Service to mankind is service to God. Sharing is the simplest form of service. Let us share what we can, wherever we can, with a pure mind and no expectation of return. In that sharing, we will not lose anything. We will shine within and we will help others shine too.

The writer is the Founder of KIIT, KISS and AoG

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

E-TENDER NOTICE NO.: 08/2026Date : 11.05.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr.DSTE/North Central Railway, Agra acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites "Open Tender" through Online only (E-Tendering) for the following work:

E-TENDER NO.: AGRA-ST-2026-22, **Name of work:** Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract of Railway Owned OFC Cable of Agra Division for two years.

Approx. Cost of work: ₹ 1,57,86,436.32 | **Tender closing date:** 05.06.2026

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railway Website www.ireps.gov.in. Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15.00 hrs on above mentioned date. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored.

 North central railways

 @CPRONCR

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Leyakat Ali Ansari @ Pacheich, S/o. Ganni Ansari, R/o. H. No. 9340, Katra Ganga Bisan, Kishanganj, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **FIR No.000316/2017 U/S 379/411 IPC** registered at **P.S. Roop Nagar, North District, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said accused **Leyakat Ali Ansari @ Pacheich** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Leyakat Ali Ansari @ Pacheich** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Leyakat Ali Ansari @ Pacheich**, accused of **FIR No. 000316/2017 U/S 379/411 IPC, P.S. Roop Nagar, North District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.07.2026**.

By Order, Ms. Rashi Raheja
Judicial Magistrate First Class-13,
(Central), Room No. 33, Ground Floor,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/6201/N/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1	Name of work	Replacement of steel girder by PSC slab of Br. No. 14 UP & DN DAL of (1x11.90m + 2x12.20m) clear span steel girder bridge on DBSI-ANDI and Replacement of steel girder by PSC slab of Br.No. 14 UP & DN Line of (1x11.90m+2x12.20m) clear span steel girder bridge on DLI-ROK in the section of Sr DEN-II/DLI.
2	Approx. Cost of Work	Rs. 3,24,23,440.16/- (Rupees Three Crore Twenty Four Lakh Twenty Three Thousand Four Hundred Forty and Sixteen Paise Only).
3	Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 6,48,500.00/- (Rupees Six Lakh Forty Eight Thousand Five Hundred Only)
4	Cost of tender document	Rs. 0.00
5	Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender	12.06.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
6	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in
7	Allocation	29324103

- The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system.
- For all terms and conditions, please refer tender document.
- No manual offers are acceptable.
- Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No.: 128-W/280/eTender Notice/NIT/16/2026-27-W-3 Dated: 12.05.2026 1599/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

The Chief Engineer/Const./RSP/NR, 901 B, Tower-I, 9th Floor, Connexus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender under Two Packet System for the under noted work:-

- Full Name of work :** Request for Proposal (RFP) for Appointment of Project Consultant (PC) for providing "Comprehensive Consultancy services from the stage of Feasibility Study & DPR preparation for elimination of 370 Level Crossings over Northern Railway by construction of ROB/ RUB/LHS/Other Structures/Road Diversion as required, including Detailed Design of required components of finalized scheme, Techno-Manageerial Consultancy, Project Consultants/Project Management Consultancy, Land Acquisition assistance etc. for work execution under CAO Construction (RSP) Unit of Northern Railway.
- Approx. Cost of work :** Rs. 2,24,02,13,029. 70/- Rupees Only (Two Hundred Twenty Four Crore Two Lakh Thirteen Thousand Twenty Nine and Paise Seventy Only.)
- Completion period of the work :** 108 months Period
- Earnest Money to be deposited :** Rs. 1,00,00,000.00/- Rupees only (One Crore Only.)
- Sale/availability of tender document on Rly. Website :** Tender document will be available on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 12.05.2026 to 12.06.2026.
- Last date/Time of upload of tenders :** Tender documents can be uploaded on IREPS website upto 12.06.2026, 11.30 hrs.
- Date and time of opening of tender :** Any time after 12.06.2026, 11:30 hrs.
- Pre bid Conference :** Date: 19.05.2026 Time: 12:00 Hrs to 02:00 Hrs. Venue: Office of CAO/CIRSP 9th Floor Connexus Tower, DMRC Building, Ajmeri Gate, New Delhi-110002 and through online VC link (uploaded on IREPS).

No.: 23-W-09-2026-WA-DYCE-C-RSP Dated: 12.05.2026 1599/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, देवघर
जिला परिषद बिल्डींग, सत्यनगर, देवघर

ई-अत्यकालीन पुननिविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
ई-पुननिविदा संख्या :- 12RI 2026-27/RWD/EE/DEOGHAR
दिनांक :- 12.05.2026

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, देवघर द्वारा निम्न विवरण के अनुसार e-procurement पद्धति के रूप में पुननिविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र० सं०	आईडेंटि फिकेशन संख्या / पैकेज संख्या	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (रुपये में) अंक में	अक्षर में	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	रेण्डर कॉल नं०
1.	RWD/EE/DEOGHAR/31/2024-25	ताराबाद विद्यालय रमानी टोला से बरसतिया लक्ष्मीगंजी होते हुए स्तनपुर मोड़ तक पथ निर्माण कार्य (लं०-5.900 फीटमी०) (प्रखण्ड : मोहनपुर)	6,96,80,200.00	छः करोड़ छियानबे लाख अस्सी हजार दो सौ।	18 माह	द्वितीय

- बेवसाईट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि - **17.05.2026**
- ईं० निविदा प्राप्ति की अन्तिम तिथि - **27.05.2026** अपराह्न 5.00 बजे तक
- निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय - **29.05.2026** अपराह्न 3.30 बजे।
- निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता:- कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, ग्राम० कार्य विभाग, कार्य प्रमंडल, देवघर।

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता
ग्रामीण कार्य विभाग कार्य प्रमंडल, देवघर।

PR.NO.379679 Rural Development(26-27):D

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (CIVIL) AU & PC, CSPGCL,
Shed No. 2, Dangania, Raipur-492013 Phone No. 0771-2576320 & 0771-2576324, website : www.cspc.co.in E-mail:- cecivil.au@pc@gmail.com

No.03-15/EOI/407850**Raipur, date 05.05.2026**

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

CSPGCL invite expression of interest from prospective bidders for following work :-

Sl.No.	Expression of Interest No.	Name of Work
1	CEC/AU&PC/EOI/2026/04	Invitation of Expression of Interest (EOI) for sale of fly ash /bottom ash from silos/ash dykes of 4x210 MW, HTPS, Korba West, 1x500 MW KW Extn., Korba West, 2x250 MW DSPM -TPS, Korba East and 2x500 MW ABVTPS, Janjgir-Champa of CSPGCL.

Last date of submission and opening of application is 20.05.2026 (up to 15:00 Hrs) & 20.05.2026 (at 16:00 Hrs) respectively in O/o Chief Engineer (Civil) AU&PC, CSPGCL, Shed No.- 02, Dangania, Raipur (CG). The detail can be downloaded online from https://cspc.co.in/cspgcl_tendernotices- central offices.

/Save Electricity//**samvad 47814/1**

Chief Engineer (Civil) AU & PC, CSPGCL, Raipur

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
P W.D. MAINT. DIVISION No. 1
SHED No. 7 JAWAHAR CHOWK BHOPAL

NIT No. 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22/SAC/2026-27**Dt. 11.05.2026**

//TENDER NOTICE//

Online Tenders invited for above-mentioned NIT have been processed on the e-procurement system of Public Works Department on the <https://mptenders.gov.in> Tender details are as below:

S. No.	NIT No.	System tender No.	Name of work	Probable Amount of Contract	Earnest money deposit (In Rs.)
1	16	2026_PWDRB_506456	Construction of parking shed paver bokes flooring and other work in Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukharjee College Kolar under PHQ. Section.No.1 under City Sub Dn. No.1 Bhopal.	Rs.87,00,000.00 Rs. Eighty seven lacs only	Rs. 87000.00
2	17	2026_PWDRB_506457	Various MOW. work in Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukharjee College Kolar under PHQ. Section.No.1 Bhopal.	Rs.84,00,000.00 Rs. Eighty four lacs only	Rs. 84000.00
3	18	2026_PWDRB_506458	Various construction MOW. deposit and other work under PHQ. Section No.1 under City Sub Dn. No.1 Bhopal.	Rs.70,00,000.00 Rs. Seventy lacs only	Rs. 70000.00
4	19	2026_PWDRB_506459	WW color washing distemping and painting plastering work Govt. buildings under Civil Lines Section No.2 PWD. Bhopal.	Rs.40,00,000.00 Rs. Forty lacs only	Rs. 50000.00
5	20	2026_PWDRB_506460	Various MOW AR SR deposit and other work in Civil Line Section No.2 Bhopal.	Rs.25,00,000.00 Rs. Twenty five lacs only	Rs. 50000.00
6	21	2026_PWDRB_506461	Security arrangement for different VIP. VVIP. visit programme and other law and order function under PHQ Section No.1 under PWD Maint. Dn. No.1 Bhopal.	Rs.25,00,000.00 Rs. Twenty five lacs only	Rs. 50000.00
7	22	2026_PWDRB_506463	Various MOW. AR. SR. deposit and other work in Professor Colony Section Bhopal.	Rs.25,00,000.00 Rs. Twenty five lacs only	Rs. 50000.00

The Tender document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase and submission of tender document on line is **29.05.2026** up to 5:30 P.M. Any change in the tender can be seen on the portal of above website. Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal.

Executive Engineer
P.W.D. Maint. Dn. No.1 Bhopal

G12765/26**"स्वभाव स्वकृता, संस्कार स्वकृता"**

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Vishwanath Purohit- Deceased (Through His Legal Heir) / Bhawana Purohit / LBDEL00002325463	Flat No. B7-G003, Tower-B7, Ground Floor, Gardenia Aims Glory Situated At Gh-01, Sector 46, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh- 201301/ May 08 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 18,75,533.5/-	Delhi/ Ncr
2.	Rajesh Sharma / Meenakshi Sharma / LBDEL00005464774/ LBDEL00006069186/ LBDEL00004869025/ LBDEL00005125596	Mig Flat No.B-29, Top Floor, Situated At Prem Kutir Apartments Cghs Ltd., Situated At Plot No. 25/1, Sector-9, Rohini Delhi 110085 / May 08 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 30,27,207.9/-	Delhi/ Ncr
3.	Upendra Singh Narwaria / LBDEL00004797936	Unit Bearing No. H-204, 2nd Floor (Without Roof Right) Tower-H, Skytech Martret, Situated At Plot No Gh-01/D, Sector-76, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh 201301 / May 08 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 16,69,293.48/-	Delhi/ Ncr
4.	Amit Verma/ Ila Malla / TBGHZ00007321374	Apartment No-1401, 13th Floor,tower-D, (Without Roof Right) ,Elite Golf Greens' Situated At Plot No Sc-01/D4, Sector 79, Noida Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh- 201301/ May 08 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 1,60,97,085.78/-	Delhi/ Ncr
5.	Pankaj Kaushik-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir) / Gunjan Kaushik / LBND000002198443	Flat No A4/1002, 10th Floor, Tower-A4, The Romano, Situated At Plot-001 Sector 118/GHP Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh- 201301/ May 08 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 61,97,920.89/-	Delhi/ Ncr

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 14, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.,

JHARKHAND BIJLI VITRAN NIGAM LIMITED
(CIN:U40108JH2013SGC001702)
ELECTRIC SUPPLY CIRCLE, CHAS
Reg. Office : Chas Block Road, ITI More, Chas, (Bokaro), Pin- 827013,
Email ID- esechas011@gmail.com

TENDER NOTICE

Sealed Tender in two parts Part-I (Technical and Commercial) and Part-II (Price part) are invited from the reputed tenderers having good experience of following similar nature of civil works and having financial soundness status.

Sl. No.	NIT No.	Name of Work	Estimated cost (In Rs.)	Earnest money to be deposited (In Rs.)	Cost of BOQ including GST @ 18 % (Non-refundable) (In Rs.)	Time of completion of work
01)	81/PR/JB VNL/ 2026-27	Sinking of 200/165 mm dia HYDT deep bore well with allied work related to water supply system at 33/11 KV P/S/S, Sahubahiyar under Electric Supply Division, Loyabad.	3,71,100=00	7,500=00	885=00	60 Days
02)	82/PR/JB VNL/ 2026-27	Sinking of 200/165 mm dia HYDT deep bore well with allied work related to water supply system at 33/11 KV P/S/S, Tilantand (Katras) under Electric Supply Division, Loyabad.	3,82,300=00	7,700=00	885=00	60 Days

Last date and time for sale of BOQ/ Tender documents 04/06/2026 up to 5.00 PM

Last date and time for physical submission of tender documents 05/06/2026 up to 02.30 PM

Date and time for opening of tender Part-I (Technical and Commercial) 05/06/2026 at 3:00 PM

Date and time for opening of tender Part-II (Price Part) Further communicated

Tendering Officer and address for communication Electrical Superintending Engineer, ESC-Chas

- Tender documents with BOQ including term & conditions, specification etc. can be purchased on mentioned cost either in cash or in shape of Demand Draft from the office of the undersigned during office hours up to last date of sale of BOQ/Tender documents.
- Demand Draft from any nationalized/Scheduled bank of India towards requisite amount of Earnest money and/or cost of BOQ may be made in favour of **Accounts Officer, Electric Supply Circle, Chas**, payable at **Chas**.
- The tenders will be received through offline tendering mode only.

स्वहित एवं राष्ट्रहित में कर्जा बचाव। कृपया अपनी शिकयतों को 18002468570(कील सेंटर) पर दर्ज करवाएं।**Sd/-**

Electrical Superintending Engineer
Electric Supply Circle, Chas

PR 379686 Jharkhand Bijlee Vitran Nigam Ltd(26-27).D

GOVERNMENT OF CHHATTISGARH, WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
WATER RESOURCES DIVISION, PENDRA ROAD (C.G.)
e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
eProcurement Portal: <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>
(First Call)

System Tender No. : 190717/ NIT No. : 01/SAC/2026-27**Dated : 13.05.2026**

Online Tenders are Invited for The Following Works up to 03.06.2026 at 17:30 Hour

Name of Work : CONSTRUCTION WORK OF C.G.LINING RD 12000 M.TO 15000 M. OF KHONGSARA DIVERSION SCHEME IN KOTA BLOCK OF BILASPUR DISTRICT.

Probable Amount : Rs. 158.22 Lakhs

The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the govt. of Chhattisgarh Integrated e-procurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) from dated **20.05.2026 at 17.31 hours (IST)** onwards.

Note : 1. All eligible/interested contractors/ bidders are mandated to get enrolled on the integrated e-Procurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) and get approval on specific vendor class from F40D under centralized contractor / supplier registration in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process.

2. Probable Amount of Contract (P.A.C.) is as per S.O.R. 01.05.2025. (As Amendments 08.08.2025).

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
WATER RESOURCES DIVISION
PENDRA ROAD (C.G.)
For, Chief Engineer
Hasdeo Basin, Water Resources Deptt
Bilaspur (C.G.)

G 262700700/4

PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Amit Kumar Dung/ Riya Dung/ LBGHZ00004928948/ LBGHZ00004929030	Flat No S-2 (M.I.G.), 2nd Floor, Built on Plot No 962, Shalimar Garden Ext-I Village Hadbast, Pargana Pasunda Tehsil Launi Ghaziabad- 201001/ May 11, 2026	August 22, 2024 Rs. 23,97,402.80/-	Delhi/ NCR

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 14, 2026
Place: Delhi/ NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.,

SHREE SAIBABA SANSTHAN TRUST, SHIRDI
Post - Shirdi, Tal. - Rahata, Dist. Ahilyanagar,
Phone No.(02423) 258500/259180/250302,
Website - www.sai.org.in E-Mail- dwaraawati@sai.org.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited on out source basis for Dwarawati Bhaktniwas for the work of Housekeeping, cleaning and pest control works etc. as well as mechanised housekeeping for Dwarawati Bhaktniwas for the duration of 2026-28 a: 21 month on Date: 01/07/2026 to 30/03/2028.

- For E-tender criteria terms/conditions and e-tender information visit Sri Saibaba Sansthan official website www.sai.org.in/tender.
- The e-tender for online downloading and uploading Dt. 14/05/2026 from 11.00 am to Dt. 25/05/2026 till 05:00 PM will be available at www.mahatenders.gov.in.

(Goraksha Gadilkar, I.A.S.)
Chief Executive Officer.

DGIPR/2026/2027/750

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Puttu Lal (Through His Legal Heir)/ Vimla/ LBDEL00002893307	Flat No, C-201, 2nd Floor Tower C, Oxirinch New Delhi Extension Koyal Enclave Ghaziabad- 201001/ May 11, 2026	October 27, 2025 Rs. 26,52,389.77/-	Delhi NCR

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 14, 2026
Place: Delhi/NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.,

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C/84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) **SUSHIL S/o Om Dass R/o Rajiv Gandhi Market, J.J. Colony, Shakupur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 99/2020 U/s 12/9/55 Gambling Act, PS Subhash Place, Distt. North-West, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **SUSHIL** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **SUSHIL** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **SUSHIL** of **FIR No. 99/2020 U/s 12/9/55 Gambling Act, PS Subhash Place, Distt. North-West, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **06.07.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order
M/s Upasana Satija
Chief Justice Magistrate (N-V)
Room No. 108, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6238/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. AGC-ELG-T-05-2026-27Date : 12.05.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N.C. Railway, Agra for and behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No. : AGC-ELG-T-05-2026-27

Name of work with its location & Completion Period : Miscellaneous works under SSE/PM/TJ for 02 years (MTJ-PWL Section).
Completion period - 24 months

Approx Cost of the work : Rs. 4736286.05/- (including GST)

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. •Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on **04.06.2026 1063/26 (AS)**

 North central railways

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

 @ CPRONCR

AROUND THE WORLD

» PM Modi urges schools to consider online classes to cut fuel use

» NEET-UG 2026 cancelled over paper leak, centre orders CBI probe

» IIT Guwahati launches hybrid MTech in Robotics and AI, no GATE required

» Jaipuria Institute of Management, Ghaziabad, organizes 'Startup Conclave 2026

BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHERE IS THE SUEZ CANAL LOCATED?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our May 7 edition question: Sean Connery

Correct answers were sent by: Atanu Sinha, Debjani Mitra, Kuldeep Singh

NEWS & VIEWS

The University of East Anglia (UEA) has signed a MoU with KR Mangalam University (KRMU), a fast-growing research-oriented institution in India, to introduce a BBA Semester-Abroad Programme. This is a first-of-its-kind initiative designed to deliver a seamless, globally integrated academic experience to Indian students.

A new study by IIT Gandhinagar IITGN researchers found that while urban greening remains essential to reduce heat stress, cities need smarter and more climate-responsive planning to ensure that tree cover delivers maximum cooling benefits. However, cooling benefits of vegetation can vary significantly depending on humidity.

NATIONAL TECHNOLOGY DAY

85% INDIAN STUDENTS NOW RELY ON AI FOR ACADEMICS: SURVEY



13% of the students turn to AI tools to complete homework assignments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India is witnessing an unprecedented wave of technological advancement, propelled by a national AI strategy, forward-looking government policies, and an ambitious goal to boost AI talent, infrastructure, and adoption. A recent survey across students, parents and teachers in North India like Delhi NCR, Haryana, Chandigarh, Lucknow and Meerut shows over a third 34% use AI to understand complex topics and concepts, 27% rely on it for general knowledge and research, and 13% turn to AI tools to complete homework assignments. Additionally, 21% of students report using AI for personal interests such as improving language skills, exploring hobbies like sports, music, or literature, and just under 3% say they have used AI for social-emotional support or to navigate life skills. The findings reveal that 85% of students in Grades 9-12 are already using

21% of students report using AI for personal interests such as improving language skills, exploring hobbies like sports, music, or literature

of parents are comfortable with their children using AI at school, citing benefits like self-paced progress and targeted help, concerns remain. More than six in ten parents admit they do not actively guide their children on responsible AI use, echoing national trends and highlighting the need for better resources and communication around digital literacy, data privacy, and screen time. Despite these challenges, the ecosystem is overwhelmingly optimistic. The majority of students in the survey conducted by Silverline Prestige School express a desire for even more AI-powered resources, while teachers and parents are open to upskilling and collaboration. With students setting the pace and adults closing the knowledge gap, India's K-12 ecosystem stands on the threshold of an AI-powered transformation, one where energy, ambition, and collective action can set a new global standard in education.

In AI world, future belongs to those who can think beyond the machine

DR AMIT SAXENA

What should I really study? Will AI take over careers before I even begin mine? Which skills will still matter in the next decade? These are no longer occasional questions from students, they are becoming the defining concerns of an entire generation. As educators, parents, and industry leaders, we stand at a remarkable turning point where the world is changing faster than traditional education systems can adapt. Artificial Intelligence (AI) is no longer a distant concept confined to technology companies or research labs. It is now embedded into everyday life, shaping businesses, redefining industries, and transforming the way people work, communicate, create, and learn. From finance to healthcare, marketing to manufacturing, AI is rapidly automating routine tasks and enhancing productivity at unprecedented levels. Yet, amid all this technological advancement, one truth remains unchanged: Machines may process information faster, but human beings create meaning. This is precisely why the future will belong not merely to students who can use AI tools, but to those who can think beyond them. Today, information is abundant. Answers are available in seconds. But the real differentiator is no longer access to knowledge, it is the ability to ask the right questions, apply judgment, think critically, and connect ideas with empathy and purpose. The world does not need graduates who simply memorize concepts. It needs individuals who can solve complex problems, collaborate across cultures, communicate effectively, and lead with emotional intelligence. These are deeply human capabilities that no algorithm can fully replicate. At Sparsh Universe, be it in our K12 or higher education institutions, this shift compels us to rethink the purpose of education itself. Education can no longer remain limited to textbooks, examinations, and theoretical learning. It must become experiential, interdisciplinary, industry-connected, and future-focused. Students today must learn how to: » Think analytically while remaining creative » Use AI responsibly without becoming dependent on it » Adapt continuously in a rapidly evolving world » Build resilience, ethics, and leadership » Combine technological understanding with human sensitivity AI will certainly transform jobs, but it will also create entirely new opportunities for those prepared to evolve with it. History has repeatedly shown that while technology changes industries, human imagination continues to shape civilization. The winners of tomorrow will not necessarily be those with the highest marks or the most degrees. They will be those who remain curious, adaptable, emotionally aware, and capable of lifelong learning. In many ways, we are entering an era where education must move from "teaching students what to think" toward "teaching them how to think." The author is the CEO of Sparsh Universe



Trending COURSES

'OUT OF THE BOX THINKING' COURSE FROM IIT MADRAS PRAVARTAK

OUR CORRESPONDENT

ITM Pravartak Technologies Foundation has commenced registrations for 2026 batch of its popular 'Out Of The Box Thinking' (OObT) course, a unique online learning initiative designed to help learners solve problems creatively through mathematics and logic. The OObT course focuses on using mathematics as a tool to develop broader thinking skills rather than rote problem-solving. It introduces learners to indirect and creative approaches to solving challenges, encouraging them to move beyond conventional step-by-step methods. Through engaging modules, puzzles, patterns,

logic-based exercises and real-world applications, participants learn how to analyse situations from multiple perspectives and arrive at innovative solutions. The last date to register is July 31, 2026. Conducted fully online, the course is structured to make high-quality learning accessible to students from urban and rural India alike, while also welcoming college students, working professionals, teachers and researchers. Topics span number theory, geometry, counting techniques, ratios, statistics, algebra, visual mathematics, calendar mathematics, logical puzzles and advanced problem-solving frameworks.

Students want less politics, more studies on Bengal campuses

ADRITA BHATTACHARYA

Times change, governments change, but campus politics doesn't. Yet, every new beginning also brings fresh hope. With the change in power in West Bengal, many students are now hoping for a more balanced and academically focused atmosphere in colleges and universities. Adrija Sen and Parinita Chatterjee (names changed), both students of Asutosh College, recall how members associated with the former ruling party's student wing would often encourage students to participate in rallies and campaigns. According to them, refusing such requests was not always easy. "At times, there was a feeling that participation in rallies could indirectly affect classroom relations and internal assessments," said Sen. Chatterjee added that she now hopes the new student leadership will allow students to focus more on academics without unnecessary interference. After the BJP came to power in Bengal for the first time with a massive mandate, leaders of Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the student wing affiliated to the BJP, claim to have expanded their presence across nearly half of the state's educational institutions. Students across campuses say they are hopeful that the changing political landscape could lead to a healthier academic environment. Rahul Mehta from Prafulla Chandra College said students often felt pressured not only inside campuses but also through messages in student group chats. At the same time, students continue to raise concerns over issues such as academic freedom, campus security, and infrastructure. Ayush Gupta, another college student, alleged that some senior members of student unions from TMCP, the student wing of TMC, would collect money from juniors on occasions such as birthdays, making many students uncomfortable. Most colleges in Bengal have not witnessed student union elections for several years. Although the former ruling party is no longer in power in the state, how campus politics will evolve in the coming months, especially with the growing role of the ABVP, remains to be seen. For now, many students are simply hoping for campuses where academics take precedence over politics.

ADMISSION ALERT

IIM SAMBALPUR INVITES APPLICATIONS FOR SECOND BATCH OF UG COURSES

Applications for 2026 academic session are now open

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IIM Sambalpur is inviting applications for its second batch of four-year Bachelor of Science courses for the academic year 2026. The institute has two Bachelor of Science courses including BS in Data Science & Artificial Intelligence and BS in Management & Public Policy. Both these courses are designed keeping in mind the goals of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. Designed to address the needs of contemporary occupations, the programmes include important aspects like data science, management, public policy, and sustainability, providing students with the opportunity to gain technical as well as soft skills necessary for the current work culture. Applications for the 2026 academic session are now open.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

» Curriculum aligned with the latest industry trends and academic research frontiers

» Multi-disciplinary curriculum that brings together management, marketing, technology, AI, Operations, policy and analytics

» Real-world exposure through live projects, internships, industry collaborations and field immersions

» Final year capstone project and dissertation addressing real-life problems

» Different exit points for students aligned with NEP 2020: Certificate (Year 1), Diploma (Year 2), Degree (Year 3), Honours (Year 4)

ONE IN 3 BFSI EMPLOYEES PLAN TO QUIT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BFSI's next big risk isn't financial. It's workforce readiness. India's banking, financial services, and insurance sector is facing a looming retention crisis, with one in three employees currently planning to leave their jobs. Roles are evolving faster than job design, skills remain uneven, leading to dependency and burnout, and learning systems lag rapid change, even as nearly half the workforce requires reskilling. As expectations compound, the burden shifts to managers and front-line teams, creating execution stress despite strong business performance. The leadership imperative has therefore moved from initiating change to ensuring people and systems operate reliably at scale. The report by Great Place To Work India titled, 'People Reality in BFSI- Three workforce Imperatives' highlights AI is advancing rapidly and accelerating how work gets done, reshaping BFSI roles faster than organizations can redesign them. A solid with 83% of employees across BFSI expressing positive sentiment towards AI at work, with 87% of employees identifying automation of manual tasks and increased speed and efficiency as the primary benefits of AI at work. The report mentions that the future of BFSI will be decided by transformation intent and by the resilience of its people management. Organizations that redesign roles alongside technology, strengthen everyday leadership behaviours, and accelerate learning in step with change will be best positioned to deliver sustainable performance without eroding trust or wellbeing.